Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Numbers

Numbers 1:1

- In the year after Israel left Egypt, the Lord often communicated his will to the people through Moses, giving them many chances to follow his divine plan.
- God often revealed himself in the Tent of Meeting; see study note on Exodus 27:21.
- The wilderness of Sinai was a vast, frightening, and harsh desert (Deuteronomy 1:19). This mostly empty area was where God matured Israel. The challenges of Sinai's harsh living conditions tested Israel's reliance on the Lord throughout the book of Numbers. Sinai reminded later biblical authors of the law and Israel's rebellious spirit (Psalm 106:19; Hebrews 12:25–26).

Numbers 1:1–16

God chose a family leader from each tribe (except the tribe of Levi), to count Israel's men who were old enough to be soldiers.

Numbers 1:1–10.10

The Israelites got ready to leave for the promised land by listing all troops who could join the conquest. The nation was changing from slavery to becoming a nation.

Numbers 1:2–16

- those who are twenty years of age or older by their divisions—everyone who can serve in Israel's army: This registration gathered more information than the earlier census (compare Exodus 38:26).
- These are the names of the men who are to assist you: Hebrew culture was tribal, centered around clans and families. They easily identified the tribal leaders, who appear again as a group in Numbers 7.
- Moses and Aaron did not include the tribe of Levi in this registration because it had a special status in Israelite society (see Numbers 1:47–53; 26:51–62; Deuteronomy 18:5; 33:8–11).

Numbers 1:16

These tribal leaders proved to be responsible and trustworthy by completing other important tasks.

Numbers 1:17–46

The count of 603,550 shows the same number of qualified men as mentioned in Exodus 38:26. Exodus 12:37 and Numbers 11:21 give an approximate number of 600,000.

People have interpreted these numbers in different ways:

- The numbers might show the actual size of this army (see Exodus 1:9–10).
- The numbers might be symbolic. A later editor might have estimated, or might have misunderstood while translating.

See also study note on Exodus 12:37.

Numbers 1:20–43

The second list of tribes lists Gad with Reuben and Simeon. These two tribes camped with Gad while Israel traveled.

Numbers 1:47–54

The tribe of Levi did not serve in Israel's army like the other tribes. This part of Numbers explains how the Levites organized to serve in the tabernacle of the Testimony, which was their main duty.

Numbers 1:50

tabernacle of the Testimony: This was a portable sanctuary. It symbolized the Lord's presence and showed Israel's covenant relationship with him.

Numbers 1:50–53

The Levites had the job of setting up, taking down, moving, and guarding the tabernacle. They kept unauthorized people from coming too close or making it unclean. This protected the Israelites from the Lord's judgment.

Numbers 2:1–34

Israel organized its camps by tribal groups. This probably addressed social status, water access, and security for the Tent of Meeting. This tent represented the Lord's presence. The Egyptian army from around the same time period used a similar defensive formation to protect holy objects during their battle campaigns.

Numbers 2:2

- Each area of the Hebrew camp had family banners, probably flags or streamers (1:52). Modern Bedouins also use tribal symbols or battle flags. This shows the continued importance of tribe, clan, and family divisions.
- The tribes camped around the holy place at a safe distance (compare Joshua 3:4). This respected the

distinction between God's holiness and the non-Levitical tribes.

Numbers 2:3–9

The tribes of Judah, Issachar, and Zebulun camped in the most important spot on the east side of the Tent of Meeting. They led when Israel traveled. This largest tribal group had 186,400 people. It could protect the holy tent and its assistants very well.

Numbers 2:10–16

The tribes of Reuben, Simeon, and Gad camped on the south. They had 151,450 soldiers and marched second in line.

Numbers 2:18–24

The tribes of Ephraim, Manasseh, and Benjamin followed the Tent of Meeting and the Levites.

Numbers 2:25–31

The tribes of Dan, Asher, and Naphtali were in the back.

Numbers 2:34

At first, the Hebrews obeyed God's commands by camping and marching as Moses instructed. Yet, they soon stopped being obedient.

Numbers 3:1–4

Aaron's family line provided the priests who led Israel's worship. Aaron's four sons were the core of Israel's priesthood. They served in God's presence on behalf of the people. God chose (ordained) them to lead and serve as ministers in the Tent of Meeting. They also acted as guardians of God's covenant with his people.

Numbers 3:1–4.49

Israel's priests and Levites had duties like moving, assembling, protecting, and maintaining the Tent of Meeting. The way God organized the tribes highlighted his concern for these priestly tasks.

Numbers 3:4

- The deaths of Nadab and Abihu (see Leviticus 10:1–2) showed the need to protect the holiness of the sanctuary and to strictly obey God's instructions (Numbers 26:61; Leviticus 16:1; 1 Chronicles 24:2; compare Acts 5:1–11; 1 Corinthians 10:6–11; 11:29–30).
- Eleazar and Ithamar: See "Eleazar" Profile.

Numbers 3:5–13

God chose the Levites to be assistants for the priests, represented by Aaron. They had a number of holy duties in their ministry service. They performed holy tasks to maintain the Tent of Meeting and its items (3:7,8; explained more in 4:1–33).

Numbers 3:10

The sanctuary was set apart for God's holy use (Numbers 1:51; 3:38; 18:7). Only qualified people could approach it (compare 3:4).

Numbers 3:11–13

- every firstborn Israelite: These belonged to God because God spared them when the Egyptian firstborn sons died (3:13; see Exodus 11–12).
- I have taken the Levites: God chose the Levites to serve as substitutes for the firstborn sons.

Numbers 3:14–39

- This first phase of a two-part registration of the tribe of Levi summarized each family's special duties. 4:1–33 describes this in more detail (see 4:34–49 for the second phase). This count did not relate to military duties, so it included male Levites from the age of one month (3:40–41).
- Three family groups descend from the three sons of Levi: Gershon, Kohath, and Merari. These clans, often called the Gershonites, Kohathites, and Merarites, later inherited the "cities of refuge" (Joshua 21). They also had various important roles in the Jerusalem temple (2 Chronicles 29:3–17).

Numbers 3:27–32

Aaron and Moses, sons of Amram, were descendants of Kohath (see Exodus 6:18, 20, 26). They were caretakers of the Most Holy Place and its very holy furnishings (described in Numbers 3–4). The Kohathites were the most respected of the three clans.

Numbers 3:28

8,600: Some ancient Greek versions say 8,300. The "six" (Hebrew shsh) in 8,600 could result from misreading a "three" (Hebrew shlsh).

Numbers 3:32

Aaron's third son, Eleazar, led the Levites as an administrator. He was like an executive secretary, while his father did other tasks. He had "oversight of the entire tabernacle" (4:16–20). Eleazar had a key role during Israel's time in the wilderness. He later became the

high priest after his father (see 16:37–39; 19:3–6; 20:25–28; 26:1–3).

Numbers 3:38

The best campsite east of the tabernacle was for Moses, Aaron, and Aaron's sons.

Numbers 3:39

22,000: The numbers for each clan totaled 22,300 (3:22, 28, 34). See the study note on 3:28.

Numbers 3:40–51

There were 273 more firstborn sons in Israel from the non-Levite tribes than there were Levite males (compare Leviticus 3:39). The Levites acted as substitutes for Israel's firstborn sons (3:41; see study note on 3:11–13). The law required a redemption price of five pieces of silver for each extra firstborn son (Numbers 3:46–48; compare Leviticus 27:6).

It is unclear who paid this cost. This arrangement for special substitutes points to Christ's role as a substitute. Through his death, Christ paid the redemption price for all humanity (see Mark 10:45; Galatians 3:13; Ephesians 1:7; Hebrews 9:15).

Numbers 4:1

Moses and Aaron communicated God's will about the care and transport of the Tent of Meeting. This was the main duty of the three Levitical families.

Numbers 4:1–49

- This section continues the discussion from 3:21–37 about the duties of the three Levite clans. The Levites carried and cared for the Tent of Meeting while traveling and camping. Other tribes always surrounded them to protect them and their valuable cargo (2:17). They placed the holy items of God in the center of the tribes. The priests and their Levitical assistants kept these items holy by separating them.
- God, in his holiness, deserves to have the details of his will given careful attention. The Tent of Meeting and its furnishings were holy. The tribe of Levi had to maintain the difference between holy and common, and between ceremonially clean and unclean. This is why there is so much information about the duties of the three Levite clans.

Numbers 4:3

Out of the 22,000 Levites, only men aged thirty to fifty could serve in the sanctuary (3:39). This was because they were most capable at this time of their lives. 4:34–49 lists 8,580 qualified males. This is the summary of this registration, another "numbering."

Numbers 4:4–20

The duties of the Kohathites come first because they handled the most holy objects (see 3:27–32). This might be because Aaron and the priests came from this clan (1 Chronicles 6:2–3). Their tasks included carrying, setting up, and folding up these holy and very important coverings and furnishings.

The items entrusted to Kohath's descendants were very valuable. These included:

- the ark of the Testimony,
- the table of the Bread of the Presence,
- the lampstand (Hebrew menorah),
- the gold incense altar, and
- the altar for sacrifices.

Exodus 25–30 first describes these objects. But Numbers shows how the Hebrews used them in daily life. The Kohathites carried these items on poles or in frames. They could not touch them or enter the sanctuary to look at them, or they would die.

Numbers 4:15

Aaron and his sons, Eleazar and Ithamar, had to fully cover the sanctuary and all holy items before the camp could move. Non-Levitical tribes marched in front and behind the Levites, who carried the Tent of Meeting. The colors of the coverings showed the royalty of the objects.

They were so holy that even the Kohathites, whom God chose to handle them, could not touch the holy items, or they would die. This respect showed the holiness of Israel's Lord. Ignoring these rules was dangerous, as shown in 1 Samuel 6:19–20 and 2 Samuel 6:6–7.

Numbers 4:21–28

The men of the Gershonite clan (see 3:21–26) were responsible for general service and carrying loads (4:24). They handled the curtains, coverings, ropes, and related equipment. These were less central to Israel's worship. The duties of the Gershonites focused on the Tent of Meeting in general. This was unlike the Kohathites, who were responsible for the holy objects of the inner place of worship.

Numbers 4:29–33

This assignment to the Merarite clan involved items of lower priority than those of the Kohathites and Gershonites. It had to be done in a specific way, with

each man's load assigned by name (4:32; see also 1 Corinthians 14:40). The Gershonites and Merarites did not have the status of Kohath's family. Yet, each group helped move and set up the Tent of Meeting.

Numbers 4:34–49

The numbering and recording the Levites' names and ensuring each man understood his task was crucial. This helped properly organize Israel for travel and camping and protected the Tent of Meeting.

Numbers 5:1–4

- Modern Western people may find it difficult to understand the Old Testament laws of purity. Today, things like skin diseases, bodily discharges, or contact with a dead body are viewed mainly as health concerns. But in the Old Testament, the main concern was protecting God's holiness from ceremonial uncleanness (see Leviticus 11–15).

The community had to keep the camp holy. Nothing unclean could touch what belonged to the Lord (Numbers 5:2–3). They had to choose between having God in the camp or allowing a ceremonially polluted person stay. Both could not remain (5:3).

- The importance of purity continues from Leviticus and Numbers to the book of Revelation. Nothing ceremonially unclean will enter the New Jerusalem where God lives (see study note on Revelation 21:27). In the New Testament, impurity most often refers to what is morally impure (Acts 10:28; Ephesians 5:5; 1 Thessalonians 2:3; 4:7).

Numbers 5:1–31

These laws speak about cleanliness, repayment, and staying faithful in marriage.

Numbers 5:1–10.10

These legal matters were meant to protect the purity of the Israelites, their priests, and the tabernacle. Purity here refers to being clean and set apart for worship.

These rules helped the people remember who they were. Israel was a theocracy (a nation ruled directly by God). God was their true king.

Moses served as God's main spokesman. Through him, God gave laws and instructions to the people.

Numbers 5:2

- skin disease: The Hebrew word here describes various, contagious skin diseases (compare Leviticus 13–14).
- bodily discharge: This refers to fluids associated with sexual organs (Leviticus 15; compare Luke 8:43–48).
- a dead person: See Numbers 6:6–11; 19:11.

Numbers 5:5–10

The laws about confession and restitution show the strong Hebrew concern for moral behavior (Leviticus 6:1–7).

Confession means admitting one's sin before God. Restitution means making things right by repaying what was taken or damaged. A person who wronged another had to return what was stolen and often add more as a penalty.

Numbers 5:6

Harming another person is also betraying the Lord (literally to act unfaithful in unfaithfulness; compare Leviticus 5:8). Being right with God leads to being right with others. If we treat others wrongly, it shows our relationship with the Lord is not right.

Numbers 5:7

This restitution and the guilt offering for the sin were intended to teach personal responsibility to live holy with God (see Leviticus 6–7).

Numbers 5:8

- Since sin is ultimately against God, the one doing wrong must make restitution to the LORD (Leviticus 5:6; Psalm 51:4). God allowed the human victims of the sin to receive this payment. If no victims were alive, the priest would receive the payment on behalf of the LORD. Those doing wrong must also offer a valuable sacrifice to restore their ceremonial purity and their relationship with God (Numbers 5:1–4).
- the atonement is made for him: See study note on Leviticus 1:4.

Numbers 5:9–10

Priests partially supported their families by receiving a share of the sacrifices. Sometimes, they could sell extra sacrifices to fund the priesthood, maintain the sanctuary, and help with other religious needs (see 1 Corinthians 8:4–13).

Numbers 5:11–31

This detailed test for adultery, a "trial by ordeal," is the only one in the Old Testament. Yet, trial by ordeal was common in the ancient Near East. God had a special

interest in protecting marriage. It was the foundation of Hebrew society.

The ordeal was intended to promote marital faithfulness. We do not know how often such ordeals actually happened. This procedure relied on God to intervene so that justice occurred when evidence was lacking (see 1 Corinthians 5:5).

Numbers 5:14–15

The husband presented his case to the priest, and the "law of jealousy" (5:29) transferred the husband's jealousy and suspicion to a higher court of appeal.

Numbers 5:17

The holy water and the dust were sacred because of their association with the sanctuary.

Numbers 5:21

making your thigh shrivel and your belly swell: Thigh is a polite way to speak about the reproductive organs (compare Genesis 24:2; 47:29). Something would stop her ability to have children. The punishment matched the crime, as sexual immorality led to infertility.

Numbers 5:23–24

The image of drinking curses appears again in Ezekiel 2:8–3:3 and Revelation 10:8–11.

Numbers 5:29–31

The law describes a trial by ordeal (a test in which God was asked to show guilt or innocence). In this case, a husband could bring his wife to the priest if he suspected adultery.

The summary of the law makes one point clear. If the husband raised questions about his wife's guilt or innocence, he was not considered guilty simply for asking.

Some readers may notice what seems like a double standard. Ancient laws often focused on the woman's failure in cases of adultery. This pattern was common in the ancient world.

However, Israel's legal system did not excuse the man involved. The law required punishment for both parties in an affair (as in Leviticus 20:10; Deuteronomy 22:21–22).

Numbers 6:1–21

The voluntary vow of a Nazirite allowed men or women to separate themselves to the LORD. The Nazirite lifestyle varied throughout Hebrew history. People took vows seriously in ancient times as a way to show devotion or gratitude to God. This vow could be temporary or permanent. It involved avoiding alcoholic drinks, not cutting hair, and avoiding contact with corpses.

Nazirite restrictions allowed members of non-Levitical tribes to have a more demanding and highly respected relationship with God. The Nazirite vow is probably best known because of Samson (Judges 13–16). See also 1 Samuel 1:11; Jeremiah 35; Acts 18:18; 21:23–26; compare Luke 1:15.

Numbers 6:2

Nazirite: The Hebrew word nazir comes from a verb meaning "to separate."

Numbers 6:3–4

The law required priests to avoid drinking wine before serving in the Tent of Meeting (Leviticus 10:9). The Nazirite vow allowed non-Levites to extend this rule. They avoided wine everywhere, at all times, and anything from a grapevine.

Numbers 6:5

hair: This had a special symbolic meaning (see Leviticus 19:27). Religious people often left their hair uncut or shaved it completely (Numbers 8:5–7). The Israelites did not have to leave their hair completely uncut, but the Nazirites did.

Numbers 6:6–8

Touching dead bodies made people ceremonially unclean (9:6–10). Priests could only touch the dead bodies of close relatives (Leviticus 21:1–4). But Nazirites could not touch any dead body at all.

Numbers 6:9–21

The law gave instructions for restoring purity after unavoidable contact with a dead body. Contact with a dead body made a person ceremonially unclean (not fit for worship for a period of time). The person had to follow certain steps in order to be restored.

Special procedures and offerings also marked the end of a Nazirite vow. A Nazirite vow was a special promise to set oneself apart for God for a period of time. When the time ended, the person brought sacrifices and completed the required rituals.

The law also gives a strong warning about fulfilling the vow (6:21). A person who made such a promise had to complete it fully. God expected faithfulness in keeping vows made to him.

Numbers 6:22–27

The priestly blessing connects to the themes of worship and purity in chapters 5–6. It is a prayer where priests ask for God's blessings for Israel. As representatives of God, priests had the duty to pray (compare Leviticus 9:23; Deuteronomy 10:8). This prayer is similar to the high priestly prayer of Jesus in John 17.

Numbers 6:24

The first half of this verse asks for blessings like health, wealth, and fertility.

The second half seeks protection from all kinds of dangers. This prayer is similar to the language in Psalms 121:3–8; 140:4; and 141:9. These sincere requests are still good examples for prayer and blessings that people can seek for everyone. The entire poem emphasizes the Lord as the source of all good things.

Numbers 6:24–26

Psalm 67:1 has a short version of this blessing. This is similar to one found on a silver amulet from Ketef Hinnom, southwest of Jerusalem's Old City. A second, larger silver amulet from the same tomb has the full blessing with words almost the same as here.

The Second Temple period lasted from Ezra to the time of Jesus. Priests would give a blessing at each day's sacrifice or at the end of services. This blessing is still used in Jewish and Christian liturgy (the formal order of prayers and worship, as in 6:27).

Numbers 6:25

- may the LORD cause His face to shine upon you: This is a desire for God's approval.
- be gracious to you: God's people need his grace and mercy in a dangerous world (compare Psalms 31:16; 67:1; 80:3, 7, 19).

Numbers 6:26

God's favor, shown through his countenance or face, means his approval and special attention (compare Psalm 30:7). Divine peace (Hebrew shalom) is more than only the absence of conflict or violence. God's peace brings complete well-being, health, and wholeness.

Numbers 6:27

The priests were mediators of God's covenant with Israel. A mediator is someone who stands between two parties to represent them. The priests stood between God and the people.

Their duty was to pray for the people. They also spoke God's blessing over them. In this way, they helped maintain the covenant relationship between God and Israel (see Romans 8:34; Hebrews 2:17–18; 4:14–16). He intercedes for believers, which means he prays for them before God. As the great high priest, he brings his people into God's presence and secures God's blessing for them.

Numbers 7:1

- Moses set up the tabernacle on the first day of the second year after the exodus from Egypt (Exodus 40:1–2).
- Moses finished setting up the tabernacle. Then he anointed and consecrated it and all its furnishings, along with the altar and all its utensils (compare Exodus 40:9–10; Leviticus 8:10–11). The altar, as the place of sacrifice, was especially important among the holy furniture.

Numbers 7:1–89

This is a detailed description of the offerings made by Israel's 12 tribes during the dedication of the tabernacle. They dedicated these gifts for 12 days.

Numbers 7:2–9

- The same tribal leaders who helped with the registration in chapter 1 also appear in 7:2–3. The non-Levitical tribes gave the Gershonites and Merarites wagons and oxen to move the heavy parts of the tabernacle and other items (see chapter 4).
- These vehicles and animals were the first offerings from the Hebrew tribes (7:2). The tribal leaders also presented these practical gifts along with the more elaborate offerings they dedicated (7:10, 12–83).

Numbers 7:9

Later, the Israelites tried to move the ark of the covenant using a cart, but it ended tragically (1 Samuel 6:8, 11; 2 Samuel 6:3, 6–7).

Numbers 7:10–11

When they anointed the altar, the tribal leaders gave the wagons and oxen, silver and gold vessels, and other religious offerings for the altar. Starting with the tribe of Judah, the leaders brought these gifts to the tabernacle for 12 days. They collected these gifts from the Egyptians when Israel left Egypt (compare Exodus 12:35–36; 25:3).

Numbers 7:12–83

One by one, the tribal leaders brought their gifts for the dedication of the altar. Each tribe participated until the whole Hebrew confederation (the united group of twelve tribes) had taken part.

The text repeats the description of each tribe's gift. This repetition highlights the shared nature of the ceremony. Every tribe had a role in setting apart their place of worship for God.

The careful listing of the gifts may reflect detailed record keeping, like an archive or ledger (an official written record). The text notes that the silver bowls and plates contained grain offerings. The gold dishes held incense.

Each tribe also brought animals for a burnt offering, a sin offering, and a peace offering, as required in Leviticus. These offerings showed worship, repentance, and fellowship with God.

Numbers 7:84–88

This paragraph first summarizes the gifts and offerings from each tribe. Then it lists expensive containers, offerings, incense, and sacrificial animals. These large and costly gifts showed the importance of the altar, the tabernacle, and the God who was served there. The law required these sacrifices, but the Hebrews gave the special gifts generously.

Numbers 7:89

- After dedicating the Tent of Meeting (the tabernacle) and setting it apart as holy, it became the center of divine revelation. There, Moses spoke with God, who revealed his will and presence (Leviticus 16:2, 13–17). This communication came from the ark of the covenant. It was specifically between the two cherubim above the ark's cover, also called "the mercy seat" (compare Exodus 25:17–22).
- For the Israelites, this was the special place for atonement, similar to the significance in the Christian faith of the cross where Jesus died (see Hebrews 9–10, especially Hebrews 9:5). God's voice, heard by Moses the mediator, fulfilled the promise in Exodus 25:22 and Numbers 30:6. The Lord's presence ensured the holiness of Israel's wilderness place of worship.

Numbers 8:1–4

These verses give specific instructions for placing the lampstand (Hebrew menorah) in the tabernacle. The lampstand (see Exodus 25:31–40). It was made with branches shaped like a stylized tree.

The inside of the tabernacle had no windows, so it was dark. The light from the lampstand helped the priests carry out their duties.

Numbers 8:5–22

The Lord gave instructions for the dedication and cleansing of the Levites. The Levites were set apart to serve in the tabernacle.

Numbers 8:7

- The ceremony to make the Levites ceremonially clean involved sprinkling with water, shaving all hair, and wearing clean clothes. This was similar to ceremonies for cleansing from ceremonial impurity.
- water of purification: This phrase appears only here. The sprinkling symbolized washing away sin and had symbolic importance similar to later Jewish washings and Christian baptism. This water might have been the same as the mixture with ashes from the red heifer that removed sin (see 19:9; also Hebrews 9:13).
- Shaving their entire body was also part of being declared ceremonially clean from the ceremonial impurity of polluting diseases (Leviticus 14:8).
- Washing clothes was part of all cleansing from ceremonial impurity (for example, Leviticus 15:5–27).

Numbers 8:10–11

laying their hands on them: Israel acknowledged the Levites' special status and offered them as their representatives in the presence of the Lord (8:16).

Numbers 8:11

The mention of Aaron's raised hands suggests that Israel offered the Levites to the Lord as a wave offering. Priests would lift up this type of offering to the Lord (compare Leviticus 7:30). The Levites committed themselves to tasks that made them living and holy sacrifices (compare Romans 12:1).

Numbers 8:12–22

The Levites offered the right sacrifices before doing their work in the Tent of Meeting (8:15).

Numbers 8:19

A plague was an appropriate punishment for unlawful actions (11:33; 14:37).

Numbers 8:23–26

- These are guidelines for the length of the Levites' service.

- Whereas 4:3 says their service in the Tent of Meeting started at age 30, 8:24 says age 25. This difference might show changes in age requirements over time, depending on how many Levite men were available. Those aged 25–29 might have been unofficial workers or apprentices.
- Both passages set the retirement age at 50. Retired Levites could serve as guards of the Tent of Meeting (see Psalm 84:10).

Numbers 9:1–14

A year after Israel left Egypt, it was time for them to celebrate their second Passover in the Sinai wilderness. Those unable to celebrate at the set time could do so a month later.

Numbers 9:2–3

- God told the Hebrews to celebrate Passover at the set time (see Exodus 12:6).
- at twilight: The Hebrew day starts at sunset.

Numbers 9:4–7

When it was time to celebrate Passover, some men could not participate due to the rules in Leviticus 7:20–21. They wanted to follow the rules, but it seemed impossible for them.

Numbers 9:8

Moses agreed to ask the Lord about this difficult case (compare 7:89).

Numbers 9:9–14

God's solution to the problem was to allow a makeup ceremony one month later for two special cases (see also 2 Chronicles 30). Yet, he warned the Israelites not to neglect the Passover and to celebrate it according to the rules.

Numbers 9:12

The Israelites could not break the bones of the Passover lamb (see Exodus 12:46; Psalm 34:20; John 19:32–36; compare John 1:29; 1 Corinthians 5:7). The apostle John mentioned this instruction when he wrote that they did not break the legs of Jesus when he was on the cross (John 19:36).

Numbers 9:13

If a person refused to observe the required Passover, that person was to be cut off from the community. The Passover was a central act of worship that remembered God's rescue of Israel from Egypt.

The phrase "cut off" can have more than one meaning in the Old Testament. It may refer to the death penalty. It may also mean banishment from the community (being removed from the people). The exact meaning in this case is not fully clear (see study note on Leviticus 7:20–21).

Numbers 9:14

Foreigners who lived among the Hebrews and wanted to celebrate the Passover could do so by following the same laws, but circumcision was required for males who desired to eat the Passover meal (see also Exodus 12:48–49).

Numbers 9:15–23

This passage is similar to Exodus 40:17, 34–38. It gives more details about how God used the pillar of cloud and fire to lead his people (see also Exodus 13:21–22). The Lord was faithful and clearly guided his people in the wilderness.

Numbers 9:19–23

Even Israel's enemies saw the fiery cloud (14:14). This clearly represented God's glorious presence and the way he guided their movement.

Numbers 10:1–10

- Israel needed clear signals so the tribes could receive instructions. Two silver trumpets provided a simple and effective way to signal all the tribes to move.
- These trumpets were not the ram's horns (Hebrew shofar) often mentioned in the Old Testament (for example, Joshua 6:4–6). Israelite craftsmen made them from hammered silver brought out of Egypt.

Numbers 10:2–4

They used the two trumpets to alert people for important announcements (compare Revelation 8–11).

Numbers 10:5–8

When it was time to journey to the next destination, the trumpets sounded to signal when to camp and when to move. This sound was in addition to the movement of the pillar of cloud (compare 9:15–22 and chapter 2).

Numbers 10:8

the priests, are to sound the trumpets: They used these trumpets only for matters related to God and his rule over Israel, which the priests served.

Numbers 10:9–10

The trumpets marked holy events that people might not easily recognize. Trumpets that called to battle would remind the Lord to save the Hebrews from their enemies (Hosea 5:8; Joel 2:1).

Numbers 10:11–36

Leaving Sinai was a key moment in Israel's history. The Israelites now had the law and God would test them on how they obeyed it. The departure from Sinai marked the start of the march toward Canaan, although it became a long journey (compare Deuteronomy 1:6–8, 19). This passage summarizes the daily routines during the journey.

Numbers 10:12

The Israelites traveled to the wilderness of Paran. This region was dry and harsh. It was either arid or semi-arid, which means it received very little rain.

The wilderness of Paran lay in the northeastern part of the Sinai Peninsula. It was south of the Negev and west of the Dead Sea and the Arabah Rift (a long valley that runs from the Dead Sea southward; compare Genesis 21:21).

Numbers 10:13–28

The order of march described here is different from 2:3–34. There, all three Levitical clans carried the tabernacle and its furnishings in the center of the camp. They marched between the groups led by Judah and Reuben, and the groups led by Ephraim and Dan.

In this passage, the arrangement is more detailed. The Gershonites and Merarites carried the structural parts of the tabernacle between Judah and Reuben. The Kohathites carried the most sacred furniture between Reuben and Ephraim.

This arrangement was practical. It gave the Gershonites and Merarites time to set up the tabernacle before the Kohathites arrived with the sacred objects. This plan also provided protection for the holy items.

In addition, this pattern spread the Levites among the tribes. Their presence among the people may have strengthened spiritual influence throughout the camp (compare Matthew 13:33; 16:6, 11–12; 1 Corinthians 5:6–7).

Numbers 10:29–32

- After the journey toward Paran began, Moses asked his brother-in-law, Hobab, to guide the Israelites (literally and you will serve for us for eyes) (compare Judges 4:11). In this way, Hobab would share in their promised blessings. As a Midianite shepherd, Hobab knew the routes and possible sources of food and water in the Sinai Peninsula.
- Reuel the Midianite: See "Jethro (Reuel)" Profile.
- my own land and my own people: Midian was probably in northwestern Arabia. Judges 1:16 suggests that Hobab accepted the request.

Numbers 10:33

the mountain of the LORD: Here, this refers to Mount Sinai. In other places, it means Mount Moriah or Zion in Jerusalem (Genesis 22:14; Psalm 24:3; Isaiah 2:3; Zechariah 8:3).

Numbers 10:35

When the ark of the covenant set out, Moses called on the Lord as a warrior. He acknowledged the Lord would help Israel win the promised land and fight their battles (compare Psalm 68:1).

Numbers 10:36

This invocation (formal call for God's help) asked the Lord to be present with his people. It was spoken when the Israelites set out or camped.

Numbers 11:1

- Soon the people began to complain ... fire from the LORD blazed: The link between Israel's complaints and God's punishment is a major theme in Numbers and throughout the Old Testament (for example, Deuteronomy 9:22; Psalm 78). God is holy and just, and he demands obedience from his people. Complaints are the same as rejecting him (compare Numbers 11:20).
- their hardship: Mount Sinai had been a stable home for a year. The journey to Paran brought heat, thirst, and fatigue.
- consumed the outskirts of the camp: Compare Leviticus 10:2.

Numbers 11:1–35

This is one of many occasions in the wilderness when Israel was disobedient to the Lord.

Numbers 11:2–3

- The people asked Moses to speak to God again on their behalf. This stopped the fire of God's judgment (compare Exodus 15:25; 32:11–14).
- Taberah: Compare Numbers 11:34–35; see Deuteronomy 9:22.

Numbers 11:4–6

Who will feed us meat?: The Israelites had flocks and herds (for example, 32:1; Exodus 12:32, 38; 17:3; 34:3). But the animals were more valuable for their dairy products and other benefits while alive. They only butchered them for meat occasionally. The Hebrews did not have enough meat to regularly feed such a large population (compare Numbers 11:21–22).

Numbers 11:4–15

Israel had not given up the attitude that led to judgment at Taberah (11:1–3). At Taberah, the people complained, and the Lord sent fire among them.

Soon after, they joined the foreign rabble (a mixed group of non-Israelites who had left Egypt with them) in craving the foods of Egypt. They longed for the fish, vegetables, and other foods they had known there.

In doing this, they forgot the suffering and slavery they had experienced in Egypt. They remembered the food but ignored the hardship.

Numbers 11:6

The Lord had earlier provided manna and quail (Exodus 16).

Numbers 11:7–9

People often explain manna as a naturally occurring edible substance (but see Deuteronomy 8:3). Yet, its amount and how long it lasted was miraculous.

Numbers 11:10–15

- The Israelites' constant complaining frustrated Moses, leading him to express his own complaints to God. With extreme sarcasm, Moses reminded God that he had not wanted this responsibility (compare Exodus 4:10). Israel became such a burden that Moses wished God would do him the favor of ending his life (compare Job 6:9).
- Moses' complaint was acceptable, unlike the people's complaints, because he sought the Lord instead of longing for Egypt's pleasures.

Numbers 11:16–30

Jethro suggested that Moses should have different levels of judges (Exodus 18:13–26). He focused on practical issues like the tribal leaders who helped Moses with the registration (Numbers 1:5–15).

In contrast, the group of 70 elders would give Israel spiritual guidance. They needed a share of God's Spirit. Moses already had this, and it made him the Lord's special spokesman. Their ability to lead depended on God's Spirit being with them (compare 1 Samuel 10:6; 19:20; Joel 2:28; Acts 2:16–18; 1 Corinthians 12:10; 2 Peter 1:20–21).

Numbers 11:25

The text does not describe what happened when the Spirit rested on them and they prophesied. It only says that they spoke as the Spirit enabled them.

Whatever took place, it may have included ecstatic speech (intense or Spirit-driven words spoken in a special way). Similar events appear later in Acts 2:4 and 1 Corinthians 14:2. However, the text suggests that this was a unique event.

Numbers 11:28–29

Joshua's worthy jealousy was a desire to safeguard his master's status. But, Moses was humble and did not feel threatened by Eldad and Medad's prophecy (Numbers 12:3). Instead, he was glad to see God working through others in special ways. Moses had leadership qualities that the younger Joshua had not yet developed (compare Mark 9:38–40).

Numbers 11:31–35

God answered the people's complaints by sending a storm of quail and a plague. God had given quail with manna in Exodus 16:13. But here the quail showed God's judgment through an excessive abundance.

Numbers 11:34–35

The exact locations of Kibroth-hattaavah and Hazeroth are unknown.

Numbers 12:1

Most interpreters believe the Cushite woman is Zipporah, the wife of Moses. She was from Midian (Exodus 2:16–22). They see Cush as referring to Cushan, a region and people near Midian (Habakkuk 3:7).

Other interpreters think Cushite refers to Kusi in northern Arabia, Ethiopia, or Sudan. This would suggest she was a different wife.

In either case, it is possible that Miriam and Aaron disapproved of his having married a non-Israelite or that they were jealous of her influence over Moses.

Numbers 12:1–2

Miriam and Aaron may have seen the marriage of Moses as a threat to their status and goals. The verses list Miriam first, suggesting she started this family

conflict. This could explain why God punished her and not Aaron (12:9–10).

Numbers 12:1–16

Rebellion did not come only from the "rabble" or from the Israelites who were tired of manna (11:4). It also came from within the family of Moses.

Aaron the high priest and Miriam the prophetess spoke against Moses (Exodus 29:30; Exodus 15:20). Their actions showed that even Israel's spiritual leaders struggled with jealousy and doubt.

At this time, Israel was moving toward a lowest point in its rebellion against God (Numbers 13:25–14:12).

Numbers 12:2

- Challenging the authority of Moses meant rejecting the Lord's choice of him as Israel's leader.
- the LORD heard this: The same phrase in 11:1 hints at the Lord's response.

Numbers 12:3

- The humility of Moses stands in sharp contrast to the jealousy of Miriam and Aaron. The text says that Moses was very humble. His character reflected a godly spirit (see also Proverbs 3:34; Matthew 5:5).
- The statement about the humility of Moses appears as a parenthetical comment (a brief note inserted into the story). It presents the truth from God's point of view.

Some think these words may have been written by Moses. Others believe they may have been added later by an editor. In either case, the comment highlights the faithful and humble character of Moses.

Numbers 12:4–8

In response to this rebellion, the Lord spoke directly. He reaffirmed the special status and authority of Moses.

Numbers 12:6–8

The Lord trusted Moses, leading to a close relationship. God communicated with prophets through visions and dreams, but he spoke to Moses face to face (literally mouth to mouth; see Exodus 33:8–11, 18–23; Deuteronomy 34:10).

Numbers 12:9–16

Miriam experienced the burning anger of the Lord (see study note on 12:1–2). When Aaron saw what happened to her, he confessed their sin and asked Moses to pray for them (compare 11:2). Both Moses and the Lord accepted Aaron's confession.

Numbers 12:14

Miriam had to follow the usual steps to become ceremonially pure after a skin disease (5:2–4; Leviticus 13–14).

Numbers 12:16

The camp in the Wilderness of Paran was at Kadesh-barnea (13:26; Deuteronomy 1:19–22).

Numbers 13:1–16

Moses chose a leader from each tribe to explore the land God promised to the Hebrews. The tribes listed are from chapter 1, but the order is different. Caleb and Joshua later prove to be men of faith (14:30).

Numbers 13:1–14.45

Twelve spies explored the fertile land of Canaan and found strong enemies defending it. Earlier chapters show Israel's disobedience, hinting at future failures. The Israelites did not have the obedience, courage, or faith to capture the land. So, the Lord made them spend 40 years in the Wilderness of Sinai. That generation did not receive their inheritance in the promised land.

Numbers 13:17–20

The scouting mission had a clear military purpose. The spies also needed to gather information about natural resources and food. These things were concerning to the Israelites since they left Egypt (chapter 11; Exodus 16).

Numbers 13:20

The season for harvesting the first ripe grapes came in late July or August, during the summer.

Numbers 13:21

- The distance from the Wilderness of Zin to Lebo-hamath in Syria was about 275 miles. The Wilderness of Zin was between the wilderness of Paran and Canaan's southern border see 34:3–5; Joshua 15:1–4). Lebo-hamath means "entrance of Hamath." This could refer to a mountain pass or a city near Hamath.
- The exact location of Rehob is unclear. But it was probably the same as Old Testament Beth-rehob, near a major route to Hamath. This text outlines the approximate borders of the promised land (see 1 Kings 8:65). The phrase from Dan to Beersheba

often marked Israel's traditional boundaries (Judges 20:1; 2 Samuel 3:10). It covered a smaller area than the territory explored by Israel's spies.

Numbers 13:21–24

The spies explored the land of Canaan. In contrast to the Sinai wilderness, it was rich and fertile.

Numbers 13:22

- Israel's spies traveled into Canaan's hill country through the Negev, the dry southern region near the wilderness of Zin. In the southern part of Canaan's central hill country, they reached Hebron. This was where Israel's ancestors had lived (Genesis 13:18; 23:19; 35:27; 37:14).
- The descendants of Anak were famous for their size and strength (for example, Deuteronomy 9:2).
- Zoan (later called Tanis by the Greeks) was a famous city in Egypt's eastern delta (see also Psalms 78:12, 43; Isaiah 19:11–13; 30:3–5).

Numbers 13:25–29

The spies agreed the land was good, but most doubted Israel could conquer it. The strong and well-fed Canaanites had built fortified towns for protection.

Numbers 13:26

Kadesh is often linked to 'Ain el-Qudeirat, a spring at the northern border of Sinai and the southern edge of Canaan. There is no evidence of a Hebrew camp there during the exodus or the wilderness wanderings. So, some scholars have suggested that ancient Kadesh was in a different location.

Numbers 13:27

The promised land is also known as land flowing with milk and honey. In biblical times, milk and dairy were key parts of the diet. Milk symbolized abundance (see Deuteronomy 32:14; Isaiah 55:1; Joel 3:18). Honey added sweetness (see Psalms 19:10; 119:103; Ezekiel 3:3; Revelation 10:9–10). The phrase describes a desirable place with plenty of food and resources (compare Numbers 16:13–14; see also Exodus 3:8; Deuteronomy 6:3; 26:15; Jeremiah 11:4–5; Ezekiel 20:6).

The New Testament emphasizes the spiritual nature of God's promises, pointing to a promised inheritance in heaven (see Romans 9:6–8; Galatians 6:14–16; Revelation 21:1–2).

Numbers 13:29

The spies answer the question of 13:18. Many ethnic groups lived in ancient Canaan.

Numbers 13:30

Caleb and Joshua (see 14:6, 10, 30) gave a more positive report about the land than the other spies did (compare 14:31–33).

Numbers 13:33

Nephilim: See the study note on Genesis 6:4.

Numbers 14:1–45

The people rejected the testimony of the faithful spies, Joshua and Caleb. Then rebellion spread throughout the community. Moses intervened to save Israel from total destruction. Those who disobeyed God died during a 40-year journey in the wilderness.

Numbers 14:3–4

- The threats they complained about were real, but the Israelites should have trusted the Lord. In the ancient Near East, victors often took wives and children as plunder after battles.
- go back to Egypt: The Israelites quickly forgot their slavery and the difficulties of the wilderness (Exodus 2:23–24; Numbers 11:1).

Numbers 14:5

Moses and Aaron bowed down to show humility, fear, grief, and anguish.

Numbers 14:6

Joshua and Caleb tried to stop the rebellion and prevent God's punishment. They tore their clothing to show their sorrow.

Numbers 14:7–9

- Joshua and Caleb realized that Israel's lack of courage and criticism of Moses and Aaron were acts of rebellion against the Lord. They knew the consequences of this rebellion.
- the LORD is with us: This was the source of their confidence (compare Romans 8:31).

Numbers 14:10

Joshua and Caleb encouraged trust in God, which led to more opposition. The protests against the leaders turned into threats against the faithful spies. All the Israelites' objections stopped suddenly. This was because the glory (Hebrew kabod) of the LORD appeared

at the Tent of Meeting, the site of divine communication (see Exodus 24:15–18; Ezekiel 1) .

Numbers 14:11

God seemed amazed that Israel still did not trust him. This was despite his miraculous rescue from slavery and provision for their needs in the wilderness (see Deuteronomy 4:32–40; Matthew 11:21; Luke 10:13).

Numbers 14:12

God is patient, but he will not tolerate open rebellion from his people (see Exodus 32:7–10).

In the New Testament, the writer of Hebrews mentions this event to strengthen the faith of Christians whose trust in the gospel was weakening (Hebrews 3:7–19; 12:3, 25; see also Psalm 95:8–11).

Numbers 14:13–25

Moses spoke to God on behalf of his people. He reminded God that his reputation related to Israel's. He pleaded for God to continue his faithfulness.

Numbers 14:17–18

Moses had used this argument before when he asked for forgiveness for Israel's rebellion (Exodus 32:10–14). Moses knew God would still punish the Israelites (Deuteronomy 7:9–10).

Numbers 14:19

Since leaving Egypt, Israel's history had been marked by repeated transgressions (acts of disobedience; chapters 11–12; Exodus 15:22–27; 17:1–7; 32:1–14; Leviticus 10).

Numbers 14:20–25

Because Moses argued with God, God forgave Israel's rebellion and did not destroy them. Yet, the stubborn generation of adults would never see the promised land.

Numbers 14:22

The people did not obey or have faith because they refused to listen to God's voice. They had seen the Lord's glory and miraculous signs (see study note on 14:10; Exodus 4:29–31; 7:1–11:10; 14:15–31; 16:1–17:13).

Numbers 14:23–25

- After leaving the promised land, God told the Israelites to march in the opposite direction.
- The Red Sea could refer to bodies of water on either side of the Sinai Peninsula (the Gulf of Aqaba or the Gulf of Suez).

Numbers 14:28

Israel's disobedience brought on the consequences they feared would come from obeying.

Numbers 14:34

- each day: Compare 13:25.
- My alienation: Compare Ezekiel 5:8; 21:3.

Numbers 14:39–45

The threat of divine punishment for their sins caused the people of Israel to feel grief. Yet, their wills remained rebellious, and they disobeyed the Lord's command again (14:25). Caleb and Joshua's based their initial confidence on God's promise to be with them (14:9). Yet, God would not fight with the Israelites until all the rebels had died.

Numbers 14:43

Because you have turned away from the LORD, He will not be with you: The prediction of Moses summarizes the entire chapter.

Numbers 14:44

The ark of the covenant represented God's presence and blessings (compare 1 Samuel 4:1–11).

Numbers 14:45

Hormah means "destruction" in Hebrew (see 21:1–3 for reference).

Numbers 15:1–3

These instructions suggest that the Israelites would eventually live in the promised land (14:31; 15:18).

Numbers 15:1–41

Chapters 1–14 cover a short time period, but chapter 15 marks the start of a long period. This is the main part of the forty years in the wilderness, about which little is known. There are references to events during this time (for example, Deuteronomy 8:2–6; 29:5–6; Joshua 5:4–8; Ezekiel 20:10–26; Amos 5:25–26; Acts 7:42–43).

During this period, Moses continued to give laws to guide Israel's life as a nation. These laws would be especially important in the future. They were meant for the day when the people who survived the wilderness would enter the promised land.

This chapter addresses three main types of laws. Numbers 15 is in the middle of stories about a stubborn and disobedient Israel. It offers hope that the promised land still waited for the next generation of Israel's people.

Numbers 15:3

an offering ... a pleasing aroma to the LORD: Honor and thanks through sacrifices and offerings pleases God.

Numbers 15:12–16

All people in the land, both Israelites and foreigners, were to be equal before the Lord in all matters (see also Leviticus 24:22).

Numbers 15:17–21

These gifts were signs of gratitude to God for the crops he provided. The people were not to give these offerings right away. They were to begin after the Hebrews reached the promised land.

At that time, they would settle there and begin planting crops. Then they would bring these gifts to thank God for the harvest.

Numbers 15:22–29

Sins done without knowing were treated differently from sins done on purpose (15:30–31). The law also made a difference between the actions of the whole community and the actions of one person (see also Leviticus 4–5).

Numbers 15:30–31

- Atonement (the way God provides forgiveness and restores a relationship with him) could be made for sins done without knowing or by accident (15:22–29). However, a person who sinned openly and proudly was treated differently (literally with a high hand; compare Exodus 14:8). Such a person showed open disrespect toward God. This was considered blasphemy (speaking against God in a dishonoring way). That person had to face serious consequences (compare Leviticus 24:10–16; see also Deuteronomy 17:2–6; Hebrews 10:26–31).
- cut off from among his people: See study notes on Exodus 31:14–15; Leviticus 7:20–21.

Numbers 15:32–36

This story gives an example of what Numbers 15:30–31 teaches. The Sabbath was the Lord's holy day. The people were not allowed to ignore it or treat it as unimportant (Exodus 20:8–11; 31:14–15; 35:1–3).

Numbers 15:34

Although it was clear that the man was guilty, the community might have been unsure about his punishment. The death sentence was appropriate because ignoring the Sabbath showed a rejection of God's gracious covenant with Israel (Exodus 31:12–17). It was similar to blasphemy (Numbers 15:30; Leviticus 24:10–16; compare 1 Timothy 1:20).

Numbers 15:37–41

- If the Hebrews had remembered their special relationship with the Lord, they might have avoided the problems in Numbers. The tassels reminded Israel of their unique bond with a holy God and his expectations. He had freed his people from Egypt. Consistent with his call to a covenant relationship, he expected them to observe the law (see Deuteronomy 6:6–9; Matthew 9:20; 14:36; 23:5).
- The color blue was a sign of royalty, which means kingship or rule. It also reminded the people of God's holiness.

Numbers 16:1–17.13

Another rebellion demanded a clear separation of duties between priests and Levites. This power struggle was more serious than previous rebellions against God's authority (chapter 11; 12:1–15; 14:1–45).

In these historical events, the rebels protested minor issues and questioned their leaders' actions. Yet, Moses reminded them that they were actually rebelling against God. As a result, the Israelites suffered deadly consequences for their rebellion.

Numbers 16:3

The rebels "envied Moses, as well as Aaron" (Psalm 106:16). They claimed Moses and Aaron had overstepped their authority because all Israelites were God's chosen people (Exodus 19:6). Their protest for equality against Moses and Aaron's authority probably intended to replace it with their own.

Numbers 16:4–7

Moses ... fell facedown on the ground to pray (compare 14:5; 16:22). Then he challenged Korah and his followers to a test.

Numbers 16:6

Take censers: Korah and his group were to act like priests by burning incense (as in Leviticus 16:11–13). By doing this, they were claiming the right to serve as

priests. God himself would decide who truly had the right to serve in that role.

Numbers 16:10

Chapters 3–4 describe the special ministry duties of the Levites. Aaron's descendants had the priesthood (3:1–4). The rebels complained against the Lord, not Moses or Aaron.

Numbers 16:13

land flowing with milk and honey: This phrase repeats the words the spies used earlier to describe Canaan (Numbers 13:27). In this story, however, the words are used with sarcasm.

The speakers twist the meaning on purpose. They use this phrase to describe Egypt in a positive way. This distorts the truth about life in Egypt, where the Israelites had lived as slaves (see study note on 11:4–15).

Numbers 16:14

- The Israelites were leaving their new homeland because they had rebelled against Moses. He had done everything possible to bring them to that land (chapters 13–14).
- Will you gouge out the eyes of these men?: They accused Moses and Aaron of trying to mislead the Israelites.

Numbers 16:15

Do not regard their offering: Compare Psalm 109:7 and Proverbs 28:9.

Numbers 16:16–17

Moses gave final instructions for a test to see if the Lord would accept the rebels' offering or Aaron's offering.

Numbers 16:18–22

At the height of the rebellion, the Lord intervened to save Moses and Aaron. Moses and Aaron then prayed for the people.

Numbers 16:19

had gathered his whole assembly ... at the entrance of the Tent of Meeting: This was either to watch the test or to remove Moses and Aaron from leadership.

Numbers 16:21–26

The Lord threatened to destroy the entire community because of widespread sin (compare Genesis 18:16–33). Moses and Aaron prayed to limit the Lord's judgment to those guilty of this specific rebellion.

Numbers 16:26

Do not touch anything that belongs to them: These men and their belongings were now "set apart for destruction" (see Leviticus 27:28–29; compare Deuteronomy 7:26; 13:17; Joshua 6:18; 7:1–26).

Numbers 16:28–30

- Moses believed that God would deliver justice, and God did so (16:31–35; compare 1 Kings 18:18–40).
- into Sheol: This was the place of the dead in the Old Testament. Sheol describes the realm where people go after death (see 1 Samuel 2:6; 2 Samuel 22:5–6; Job 3:20–22; Psalm 16:10; Acts 2:27–33; 1 Corinthians 15:15; Revelation 20:13–14).

Numbers 16:31–33

Korah's sons did not die at this time (26:10–11). Later, his descendants became gatekeepers and musicians in the temple (1 Chronicles 9:19, 31; 26:19; 2 Chronicles 20:19; see the titles of Psalms 42; 45–49; 84–85; 87–88).

Numbers 16:34–35

The 250 Israelite leaders tried to offer incense even though they were not priests. Their fate was like that of Nadab and Abihu, who also offered unauthorized fire before the Lord (Leviticus 10:1–2). They also shared the same judgment as those who complained about the hardships in the wilderness (Numbers 11:1; compare 2 Kings 1:10).

Numbers 16:37

Although the men who used the incense burners were wicked, the vessels themselves were holy and had to be treated with care and respect. The burning coals were also holy and had to be scattered so that they would not be used for any other purpose.

Numbers 16:38–40

Eleazar made a bronze sheet to cover the altar, replacing or adding to the earlier one (Exodus 38:2). Like the plain blue tassels in Numbers 15:37–41, it reminded the people of Israel to obey God.

Numbers 16:41

The Israelites continued their self-destructive and defiant behavior, which caused their problems. They then blamed Moses and Aaron for the events.

Numbers 16:42–48

The glory of the LORD appeared again and threatened to destroy the people of Israel (see 16:19–20). Moses and Aaron intervened by falling facedown on the ground.

Numbers 16:46–50

Moses and Aaron quickly acted to save the Israelites from God's anger. Aaron used an incense burner with hot coals among the people to stop the plague.

Numbers 17:1–5

The shepherd's staff was a common item (see Psalm 23:4). Like the scepter, it symbolized authority (see Jeremiah 48:17). This trial was fitting because the Hebrew words for "staffs" and "tribes" sound the same. The Lord's chosen staff would show his chosen tribe.

Numbers 17:1–13

The Lord gave another test to make the lesson clear. This test repeated the teaching from the events in chapter 16. It also prepared the people for the instructions that follow in chapter 18.

Numbers 17:4

The staffs were in the Lord's presence, a safe place where no one could interfere with them (17:7).

Numbers 17:8

- Aaron's staff ... produced almonds: This proved he was God's chosen leader and that the Levites had a special role. The cups on the lampstand of the Tent of the Testimony (the tabernacle) had the shape of almond blossoms (Exodus 25:33–36). Later, the prophet Jeremiah's vision of an almond branch symbolized the Lord's watchfulness and his plans to act (Jeremiah 1:11–12).
- There is no natural reason for Aaron's staff to bud. Almond wood is soft when alive and only hardens enough for use as a staff after it has dried.

Numbers 17:9–11

After each tribal leader claimed his staff, it was clear that Aaron's deserved special treatment. They placed it permanently in front of the ark of the covenant to warn potential rebels. It would also warn Israelites who complained about the Lord and his appointed leaders. The ark of the covenant eventually contained this staff, a jar of manna, and the stone tablets of the law (compare Hebrews 9:4). This was to remind the Israelites of their time wandering in the wilderness.

Numbers 17:12–13

The Lord and his tabernacle were holy. Because of God's holiness, his holy place could be dangerous for unqualified people. Moses worked hard to help the people understand and respect the God of Israel. His efforts were becoming successful.

Numbers 18:1–4

The Lord gave special authority to Aaron, his sons (the priests), and his relatives (the Levites). They were responsible to God for offenses against the holy place. Yet, only the priests were responsible to God for their own violations of God's instructions for their service.

Numbers 18:1–32

The instructions here came from the need shown in chapter 17 for clear boundaries between the people, priests, and Levites. The Levites had special privileges and important responsibilities. One key part of their job was to protect the Tent of Meeting from unauthorized entry (chapter 16).

Numbers 18:3–4

- all the duties: See 1:47–53; 3:5–38; 4:1–33.
- they must not come near: The Levites could approach only after they had covered the holy objects for transport.

Numbers 18:5

Aaron and the priests represented the people in the presence of the Lord. Their actions affected all of Israel (see 16:18–21).

Numbers 18:5–7

Only the priests, who were Aaron and his descendants, could perform holy duties inside the sanctuary or approach the altar. This altar was a holy area that deserved special honor. Only the high priest could serve in the Most Holy Place. The Levites could only serve in the courtyard, away from the altar. The exception was when it was time to assemble or disassemble the Tent of Meeting (chapter 4).

Numbers 18:6–7

Levites ... as a gift to you: Numbers 3–4 explains this phrase. See also 3:9; 8:16, 19.

Numbers 18:7

any outsider ... must be put to death: This verse warned all Israelites to avoid areas where God did not allow them to be. God prohibited access to certain

holy places for those not qualified in a religious sense. Only the holiest members of the community could access these holy areas. Ignoring this rule meant risking one's life because it violated God's holiness (see also 1:51, 53; 3:10, 29–38; 4:1–20).

Numbers 18:8–14

The priests and Levites received support through the sacrificial system (see, for example, Leviticus 7:28–36). God's chosen representatives deserve payment for their work (compare Matthew 10:9–10; 1 Corinthians 9:3–10).

Numbers 18:9–11

- Only Aaron and his sons, the priests set apart to serve in God's presence, consumed the most holy offerings (Exodus 28:1; 29:44–46).
- This portion was a holy offering given to God, and the priests had to treat it with respect (Numbers 18:10). Other types of offerings provided food for the priests and their families, but only if they were ceremonially clean (18:11–12).

Numbers 18:14

Offerings set apart for the Lord were available to Aaron and his extended family. The Hebrew term here means a thing or person totally set apart to the Lord. This could involve either destroying or giving the person of thing as an offering. This verse speaks of an offering (see Leviticus 27:28–29).

Numbers 18:15–16

The Lord supported the Hebrew priests and their families from the offerings set aside for him. The priests received firstborn animal offerings and the redemption fee for Israel's firstborn sons. People had to redeem both firstborn sons and the offspring of unclean animals with a silver fee, since they could not sacrifice either one (see 3:13, 40–51; Exodus 13:2).

Numbers 18:19

a covenant of salt: These arrangements were part of an eternal and unbreakable covenant (see 2 Chronicles 13:5). The agreement was meant to be permanent because salt, a preservative, symbolized permanence (Leviticus 2:13).

Numbers 18:20–21

- The priests and Levites did not have a tribal homeland. They lived scattered among Israel's other tribes (see 35:1–8; Deuteronomy 12:12; Joshua 21:1–42).
- I am your portion and your inheritance: Instead of land, Israel's priests had assurance that God himself would be their homeland. The tribe of Levi received tithes as payment for their holy service.

Numbers 18:23–24

The Israelites gave a tithe, which was one-tenth of their yearly income (see Deuteronomy 14:22–29; 26:12; Nehemiah 10:35–39; Malachi 3:8–12; Matthew 23:23; compare Genesis 14:17–20; Hebrews 7:5–10).

Numbers 18:25–32

The Levites received a tithe (one-tenth) of the goods of the Israelites (18:24). However, they were not allowed to keep all of it. They also had to give a tithe of that tithe, which means one-tenth of the one-tenth. They gave this portion to the priests as their own harvest offering (18:27).

Numbers 18:31

Levites and their families could eat any food received as tithes. This food was their payment for working at the Tent of Meeting.

Numbers 18:32

The food tithes were holy gifts from the people of Israel. They could not use these gifts for something common by failing to give a portion to the priests.

Numbers 19:1–10

They made the water for the purification ceremony with ashes of the red heifer (19:9). It might be the same as the water of purification in 8:7 (see also 31:19–24). This ceremony needed the ashes of a red heifer. The color probably represented blood (compare Hebrews 9:13–14).

Numbers 19:1–22

This section explains how ordinary Israelites can become ceremonially clean again after touching a corpse and avoid defiling the Tent of Meeting (see 9:4–12; Leviticus 17:15; 21:1–4, 11–12). God's holiness demands that the place of his presence remains pure and separate from pollution (compare 1 Corinthians 6:9–11, 18–20).

Numbers 19:3–5

To protect Aaron's holy status, Eleazar had to perform the red heifer offering because it caused ceremonial impurity (see Leviticus 21:10–12). The red heifer ceremony differed from the regular sacrifice (compare Leviticus 4:3–12).

Numbers 19:6

The only other passage where cedar wood, hyssop, and scarlet wool appear together is Leviticus 14. That chapter describes another ceremony (also "outside the camp") that resulted in ceremonial purification.

Some scholars suggest Eleazar added cedar wood and hyssop for their aroma. Hyssop is associated with purification (Exodus 12:22; Psalm 51:7; compare Hebrews 9:19). The scarlet yarn, like the red heifer, probably symbolizes blood. Together, the cedar wood, hyssop, and scarlet wool symbolize cleansing.

Numbers 19:7–10

It required three people to produce and collect the heifer's ashes. These were Eleazar, the person who burned the animal, and the person who gathered its ashes. All three became ceremonially impure for a day because of this process. The same was true for the person who used the finished product. This was a potion made from the ash dust and water (compare 19:21). This potion had the same defiling effect as blood associated with sacrifices (Leviticus 6:27–28).

Numbers 19:9

The ceremony of burning the red heifer intended to produce ashes. They collected these ashes and stored them in a pure place outside the camp. The Israelites used them in water for purification ceremonies to remove pollution, such as contact with a corpse (19:11–22).

Numbers 19:11–19

If someone touched a human dead body, that person became ceremonially unclean for seven days (compare Leviticus 21:1–3). This meant a person was not allowed to take part in worship until they were made clean.

To become clean again, the person had to use the water of purification. This water was sprinkled on the third day and again on the seventh day.

Numbers 19:13

Becoming unclean by touching a dead body was very serious. A person who was ceremonially defiled (not fit for worship) could also make the Lord's tabernacle unclean (compare Leviticus 15:31).

Because of this danger, such impurity could lead to being "cut off" from the community of Israel. This meant being removed from the people, and in some cases, it could mean death (see Numbers 9:13; Exodus 12:15; Leviticus 7:20–21; Leviticus 17:4–14; Leviticus 20:17–18).

Numbers 19:14–16

Death made a person ceremonially unclean, and this uncleanness could spread. It could pass to an object or to a place where someone had died (compare Leviticus 15:1–12). This means that anything connected to the dead body could also become unclean. People had to be careful so that impurity did not spread through the camp.

Numbers 19:17–22

To cleanse with the heifer's ashes, they made a special purifying mixture. They combined ashes from the burnt purification offering with fresh water (compare 5:17).

Numbers 20:1

Everyone in Miriam's generation also died (14:26–30). This included Moses and Aaron (20:2–13, 22–29).

Numbers 20:2

there was no water: Most of the year, Sinai and the Negev are very hot and dry.

Numbers 20:2–13

The people of Israel complained again about not having water and food (compare 11:4–35; 21:4–5; Exodus 15:22–25). So, Moses and Aaron disobeyed the Lord. As a result, they lost the privilege of entering the promised land.

Numbers 20:3

our brothers: This shows that the Israelites saw themselves as connected to those who had died:

- Nadab and Abihu (Leviticus 10:1–5),
- those who died during the first plague after craving meat (Numbers 11:33),
- the skeptics who died in the wilderness (14:29),
- the ten unfaithful spies (14:36–37),
- Korah, Abiram, and Dathan (16:32),
- the 250 leaders (16:35), and
- the 14,700 people who died in the second plague (16:49).

Numbers 20:6

They fell facedown: As in earlier conflicts, they lay down and waited for the Lord's glorious presence to resolve the crisis (14:5, 10; 16:4, 19, 22).

Numbers 20:7–9

God heard Israel's complaints and accepted them as valid. He did not ignore their concerns.

Then God told Moses to deal with the problem and provide a solution.

Numbers 20:8–9

Moses placed the staff in front of the ark of the covenant to stop the Israelites from complaining (compare 17:10). The staff represented God's authority given to Moses and Aaron. God's instructions to his representatives are very precise and require exact obedience (compare James 3:1; also see 2 Timothy 2:24–26).

Numbers 20:10–12

Instead of obeying God's instructions with respect, Moses criticized the people (Must we bring you water out of this rock?). Moses then hit the rock twice with his staff (20:11). God considered the words and actions of Moses as a serious lack of faith. Moses "spoke rashly" (Psalm 106:32–33; compare James 1:20). Moses did not trust God enough to show God's holiness to the people.

God had told Moses exactly what to do. By acting differently, Moses showed a lack of faith that God would provide for his people. His angry words also revealed this lack of trust.

The Lord requires obedience and faith. Anything less dishonors his holy character (Numbers 20:24; 27:14). Such a serious lack of obedience and faith led to the same outcome as earlier (14:20–23; see also 1 Corinthians 10:4–12).

Numbers 20:13

- Meribah means "Arguing" or "Quarreling." As they had earlier at Rephidim(Exodus 17:1–7), the Israelites gave a name that described what happened there. The name pointed more to the event than to the place itself.
- At Meribah, God showed his holiness through judgment. He disciplined both Aaron and Moses for their sin.

Numbers 20:14–21

Israel tried to make peace with Edom, but they did not succeed. The two nations had not had contact since the time when Esau (also called Edom) and Jacob (also called Israel) buried their father Isaac(Genesis 35:29; 36:6–8; see also Genesis 32:28).

Moses sent a formal message to the king of Edom. His request followed the style of official letters used in that time. While Israel often fought with the Canaanites and other groups, they spoke politely to Edom because the two peoples were related (see also Deuteronomy 2:4; 23:7).

Even so, family ties were not strong enough to remove the old tension between Jacob and Esau (Genesis 27:41).

Numbers 20:14–21.35

The Israelites started their journey to the promised land here. They moved from Kadesh, leaving the Sinai peninsula. They entered the area east of the Jordan River, known as Transjordan. They approached the promised land from the east, taking a less direct route (see 14:25; compare Deuteronomy 2:2–6).

Numbers 20:17

- We will not ... drink water from any well: Edom was a very dry land. Food and water were limited, and there was not enough to support such a large group of Hebrew travelers.
- We will stay on the King's Highway: This road is mentioned several times in the Old Testament, but its exact path is not fully known (also 21:22). It was an official road used for government business, trade, and the movement of armies.

Along this road, travelers could find towns, food, and water between the Red Sea and Damascus. The road remained important during Roman times and even later. It was different from another route farther east called the Desert Highway, which was much harder and less welcoming for travelers.

Numbers 20:18–21

You may not travel through our land: Just as their ancestor Esau did not trust Jacob, the Edomites now did not trust Jacob's descendants (Genesis 27:36). Therefore, Israel had to turn around and find another way to approach Canaan (compare Deuteronomy 2:4–6).

Numbers 20:22–23

- Israel did not take the shorter route through the southern area east of the Jordan River. That region was the main territory of Edom (20:21).
- After they left Kadesh, the Hebrews came to Mount Hor. This mountain stood on the border of Edom. The exact location of Mount Hor is not known today. However, the Jewish historian Josephus, who wrote between AD 70 and AD 100, connected it with the region of Petra. He identified it with Jebel Haroun, which means "mountain of Aaron."

Numbers 20:24–26

Aaron's participation in the rebellion of his generation resulted in his death outside the promised land (20:10–12).

Numbers 20:27–29

- Moses transferred priestly authority to Eleazar by giving him Aaron's priestly garments (compare Leviticus 8:7–9). After this, Aaron died at 123 years old, in the fortieth year after the Hebrews left Egypt (see Numbers 33:37–39).
- the entire house of Israel mourned for him thirty days: This was a great honor (see also Deuteronomy 34:8). The usual public mourning period was seven days (Genesis 50:10; 1 Samuel 31:13).

Numbers 21:1

- the Canaanite king of Arad: It is possible that the Canaanite king of Arad felt threatened by many enemies south of his territory (compare 14:44–45). This may explain why he attacked Israel.
- Arad and Hormah (21:3) were far north of Mount Hor (20:22–29; 21:4; see study note on 20:22–23). Ancient Arad is usually identified with Tell Arad. It is west of the modern Israeli town of Arad and about 80 kilometers (50 miles) north of Kadesh.

Excavations at Tell Arad have found important remains from the Early Bronze Age (about 3300–2000 BC) and the Iron Age (about 1200–500 BC). However, there is no clear evidence that people lived there during the Late Bronze Age (1500–1200 BC), the time of Israel's exodus and wilderness journey.
Scholars have suggested several explanations:

- Some connect ancient Arad with a different site in the same region.
- Others argue that these stories were written much later and do not match archaeological discoveries.
- Still others say the evidence is incomplete and does not allow a final answer.

Similar questions about geography and archaeology appear in other parts of the Old Testament. In many cases, the available evidence does not give a certain conclusion.

- Atharim is not known from any other source.

Numbers 21:1–22.1

- As Israel journeyed to the promised land, they traveled from Mount Hor to the plains of Moab (22:1). The story of Israel's journey emphasizes the Lord's patient plan to lead Israel into Canaan despite their weaknesses.
- The general direction of their travel is clear. However, the exact path they took is not known today. Many of the places mentioned are difficult to identify.

Archaeological evidence at some sites does not match the time usually connected with the wilderness period. Because of this, there are still serious questions about geography and history in the wilderness journey.

Numbers 21:2–3

- devote ... to destruction: This phrase translates the Hebrew word kharam. This word means to devote something fully to God by destroying it. Israel was told to completely destroy their enemies and their property in certain cases (see Leviticus 27:28–29; Deuteronomy 7:2; 20:17; Joshua 6–7; 10:1–11:23).
- This battle also includes wordplay between kharam and Hormah (Hebrew khormah, Numbers 21:3). The similar sounds connect the action of destroying with the name of the place.

The event marks a turning point in Israel's dealings with the Canaanites. The Canaanites would continue to be strong and dangerous enemies during the time of the conquest.

Numbers 21:4–9

The "vow to the LORD" (21:2–3) and the resulting victory did not stop Israel from criticizing God and Moses. The long journey was a punishment for similar complaints (14:26–35).

Numbers 21:6

This entire region has been, and still is, home to very venomous snakes (compare Isaiah 30:6).

Numbers 21:7–9

- Jesus referred to this event when he explained who he is and why he came (John 3:14–15).
- By the time of King Hezekiah, around 700 BC, the bronze snake had become an object of worship in Jerusalem. The people were burning incense to it, so Hezekiah destroyed it (2 Kings 18:4).

Numbers 21:10

The location of Oboth is uncertain.

Numbers 21:11–12

- The Israelites traveled along the east side of Edom.
- Iye-abarim means "ruins of Abarim" or "ruins of the region beyond." It was probably near the northern

bank of Zered Brook (compare Deuteronomy 2:13–14). This brook separated ancient Edom from Moab (Deuteronomy 2:8–25).

Numbers 21:13

- The Israelites traveled east of the Moabite territory, located between the Zered Brook in the south and the Arnon River in the north. The far side of the Arnon River was probably north and east of the main east–west canyon of the Arnon. This huge canyon acted as a natural boundary between Moab and the Amorite territory north of the Arnon (see 21:26).
- The Amorites were a group of nomadic (traveling) peoples. During the Middle Bronze Age (about 2000–1500 BC), they conquered areas from Mesopotamia to Canaan. They even ruled important cities such as Babylon (around 1830 BC) and Assur (around 1750 BC).

Amorites living in the hill country of Canaan had frightened Israel's spies (Deuteronomy 1:26–28). Later, they defeated Israel when the people tried to enter Canaan without God's command (Numbers 14:44–45; see Deuteronomy 1:42–44).
When Israel arrived east of the Jordan River, the Amorites controlled much of that region. This area is called Transjordan, which means the land east of the Jordan (see study note on Numbers 21:26).

Numbers 21:14–15

- the Book of the Wars of the LORD: This is similar to The Book of Jashar (Joshua 10:13; 2 Samuel 1:18). The Book of the Wars of the Lord is not known from any other source.
- Waheb, a town, and Suphah, a region, are not known from any other record. Their exact locations are unknown.

Ar was one of the main settlements of Moab at that time (compare 21:28; Deuteronomy 2:18; Isaiah 15:1).

Numbers 21:16–18

The location of Beer is unknown (compare Isaiah 15:8). The short poem in this passage describes the digging of a new well. It shows the joy the people felt. In a dry region, a new source of water was a great blessing.

The poem says that princes and leaders dug the well. It also says they used scepters and staffs, which were symbols of authority. This may suggest that the digging of the well was part of a special or joyful ceremony.

Numbers 21:18–20

After moving north of the Arnon, the Hebrews left the wilderness on the eastern side of Moab and the newly conquered Amorite territory (see study note on 21:21–35). They turned west toward the ridgeline that rises up from the Jordan Rift valley, then traveled north to Pisgah Peak (see also 23:14; Deuteronomy 3:17, 27; 34:1, 5).

Numbers 21:21–22

Compare 20:14–17.

Numbers 21:21–24

King Sihon's land was between Moab and Ammon. God would not allow the Israelites to invade Ammon, Edom, or Moab (Deuteronomy 2:19; Deuteronomy 2:4–9). This was because they were relatives (Genesis 19:30–38; 32:3). Yet, Israel needed to cross Transjordan (the region across the Jordan River) to enter Canaan. Sihon's territory was the natural route.

Numbers 21:21–35

- The Israelite victories over King Sihon of Heshbon and King Og of Bashan previewed the Hebrew conquest of Canaan. It came to represent God's promise to help his people when they were in need (see 13:10–12; Deuteronomy 2:24–3:7; Joshua 2:10; 9:10; 12:1–6; Judges 11:19–22; Nehemiah 9:22; Psalms 135:10–12; 136:17–22; Jeremiah 48:45–46).
- Israel had left the wilderness before reaching Pisgah (compare Numbers 21:18, 23; 21:20). So, this story probably indicates an earlier event before the movement in 21:18–20.

Numbers 21:25

The tribes of Reuben, Gad, and Manasseh settled in the area conquered at this time (compare chapter 32).

Numbers 21:26

- Sihon king of the Amorites captured the area north of the Arnon from the Moabites, who controlled it earlier. Israel then occupied this region for several hundred years. King Mesha of Moab reclaimed it around 830 BC (see 2 Kings 3:4–27). This came through a campaign detailed on the Mesha Inscription (also known as the Moabite Stone).
- Heshbon is usually considered to be Tell Hesban. No evidence yet has shown that people lived there in the Late Bronze Age (see study note on Numbers 21:1).

Numbers 21:27–30

This ancient song may have been an old Amorite ballad about the victories of King Sihon. It may have celebrated his power and success.

Other interpreters believe that Israelite singers wrote the song later. In this view, it was a taunt song meant to mock Sihon's defeat and celebrate Israel's victory.

The flow of the story from Numbers 21:26 to 21:27 supports the first view. Israel may have taken an older Amorite song and applied it to their own victory. Sihon and the Amorites had once defeated Moab. Now Israel had defeated them. Compare Judges 11:12–28.

Numbers 21:28

King Sihon had destroyed Moab's towns from his center of operations at Heshbon.

Numbers 21:29

From the ancient point of view, even Moab's supreme god Chemosh suffered defeat at the hands of the Amorite conquerors, while the people of Moab became refugees and captives.

Numbers 21:30

The area described here is the one Israel had just conquered (21:24). The song celebrating Sihon is a fitting tribute to Israel's victory.

Numbers 21:33–35

- Ancient Bashan was east of the Sea of Galilee.
- King Og, like Sihon, was an Amorite (see study note on 21:13). Deuteronomy 3:1–11 details the story of Israel defeating Og.

Numbers 21:35

they took possession of his land: See chapter 32.

Numbers 22:1

After defeating the Amorite kingdoms, Israel settled in the plains of Moab (21:21–35 and study note). This area is on the eastern side of the Jordan Valley, northeast of the Dead Sea, and across the river from Jericho's oasis. The Hebrews camped there until they crossed the Jordan River to enter Canaan (Joshua 3:1).

Numbers 22:2–3

There is no mention of Balak outside of this event (Joshua 24:9; Judges 11:25; Micah 6:5; Revelation 2:14). Sihon, the Amorite king, had taken over his territory (Numbers 21:26). Israel had just defeated Sihon (21:21–31). Balak might have thought his small kingdom would be next.

Numbers 22:2–24.25

The story of Balak and Balaam marks an important turning point in Israel's history. It includes humor, drama, and deep teaching about God.

The story makes one main point clear. The Lord's will must be carried out. No one could stop his plan for Israel.

Numbers 22:4

Midian: This desert people descended from Abraham (Genesis 25:1–2; Exodus 2:15–16). Their agreement with Moab started their conflicts with Israel (Numbers 22:7; see 25:6, 14–18; 31:2–10; Judges 6–8).

Numbers 22:5–6

- Balaam was a pagan religious specialist called a diviner. A diviner was someone who claimed to receive messages from the spiritual world and predict the future. Balaam came from northwest Mesopotamia (see "Balaam" Profile).

Like many ancient peoples, the nations of Moab and Midian believed that spoken words had power. They believed that a blessing or a curse spoken by a skilled diviner could shape future events. Diviners claimed they had special power to discover and influence what would happen next (see Deuteronomy 18:14; 1 Samuel 6:2; 2 Kings 21:6; Isaiah 44:25; Daniel 2:1–12, 27–28; Micah 5:12; Zechariah 10:2).

Israel's enemies asked Balaam to place curses on the Hebrews. They believed that his spoken words would harm them. In the ancient world, armies often spoke curses against their enemies before battle.

People in ancient Israel also believed that spoken words could have real effect, even when they were not part of divination (for example, Genesis 27:1–40; Deuteronomy 27:15–26; 1 Samuel 14:24–28; compare Matthew 21:18–22).

- Pethor is probably the ancient city of Pitru (Numbers 22:5). It was located on the west side of the Euphrates River, south of Carchemish, about 640 kilometers (400 miles) from Moab.

Numbers 22:7

departed with the fees for divination in hand: Balaam was a professional diviner and could demand a high payment for his services (22:7, 17–18; compare 1 Samuel 9:7–8; 2 Kings 8:7–9).

Numbers 22:8

- Spend the night here: Balaam expected to receive a message from God at night (22:9, 19–20; compare Job 4:12–16; Zechariah 1:8).
- the LORD (Hebrew Yahweh): Balaam knew about Yahweh, the God of Israel, and expected a message from him about what to do.

Numbers 22:9–18

God commanded Balaam not to go with Balak's messengers.

Numbers 22:18

Some people think Balaam answered the second group of messengers in a way that tried to gain a larger reward. They suggest that he wanted a more profitable offer.

However, Balaam later said that he could not go beyond the command of the Lord, even for a great reward (24:13). This statement makes that view less likely.

Instead, Balaam appeared determined to obey the Lord. He even called the Lord "my God," which shows that he recognized the Lord's authority.

Numbers 22:19–20

Balaam agreed to ask about the Lord's wishes once more. God allowed him to go with Balak's representatives but warned him to follow God's commands exactly (see 22:35).

Numbers 22:21–41

This passage clearly uses humor to make fun of Balaam, the professional diviner. The story shows that his spiritual understanding and obedience to God were less than those of his own donkey.

Numbers 22:22

God's anger may seem surprising because he had given Balaam permission to go in 22:20. However, the Lord knew that Balaam's true motives were not as honest as he claimed when he spoke with Balak's messengers.

Balaam's harsh beating of his donkey reveals a lack of godly character (Proverbs 12:10; compare 1 Samuel 25).

Numbers 22:28–31

The only similar event in Scripture is the serpent talking to Eve (Genesis 3:1–5). God used the donkey to correct the foolish diviner (2 Peter 2:15–16).

Numbers 22:34

I have sinned: Balaam admitted he was wrong. He realized that he had not seen the angel of the Lord standing in his way. He also had not understood the angel's purpose.

Balaam offered to turn back and not continue on the journey.

Numbers 22:35

The Lord ensured that Balaam would say only what God commanded (compare 22:20).

Numbers 22:36

It is likely that this meeting place was in the northeastern corner of Balak's small kingdom.

Numbers 22:37

Balak thought Balaam did not understand how urgent the situation was nor how great the offered payment.

Numbers 22:38

Balaam's answer showed that he had learned from what happened with the donkey (compare 22:20, 35).

Numbers 22:39–41

- Balak tried to get Balaam to curse Israel. First, he used a ceremonial offering and meal to summon the gods and Balaam. Then, he took Balaam to view the Israelite camp.
- Kiriath-huzoth is an unknown location.

Numbers 22:41

Bamoth-baal means "high places of Baal." It was on a ridge of hills above the plains of Moab, northeast of the Dead Sea (compare "Bamoth" in 21:19; Joshua 13:17). It was the first of three places where the Moabite king took Balaam to view the large, spread-out Israelite camp (also Numbers 22:41; 23:14, 28). From this high point, he could see the Israelites and perform ceremonies (22:11). Balak hoped these would result in a strong curse against them.

Numbers 23:1

The number seven was a holy symbol (also 23:4, 14, 29; compare Job 42:8; see "Symbolic Numbers" Theme Note).

Numbers 23:1–30

- As a diviner, Balaam carried out rituals to look for signs about the future of Israel (compare 23:23; 24:1).

Balak had called him to curse Israel, but God repeatedly stopped him.
- These sacrifices might have related to extispicy. This was the practice of examining animal livers or other organs to predict the future. Ancient Near Eastern texts show that this fortune-telling method was common and well-developed. God had forbidden Israel from such practices (see Deuteronomy 18:9–14; compare Ezekiel 21:21).

Numbers 23:7–8

Instead of cursing Israel, Balaam spoke about their special status (compare Exodus 19:5–6; Deuteronomy 7:6–9). He recognized that God's blessing had transformed a humble people into a great nation (compare Genesis 12:2–3; 13:16; 28:14). Balaam hoped for similar good fortune for himself (Numbers 23:10).

Numbers 23:7–10

- In his first message from God, Balaam reviewed why he had come to Moab (23:5, 16). He explained how Balak had called him. He also stressed that God had a special relationship with Israel. Balaam made clear that he could not harm Israel because God was protecting them.
- These messages are written as poetry. Hebrew poetry often uses parallelism. Parallelism places two similar lines together. The second line repeats or strengthens the first line in a clear and ordered way.
- Aram: This refers to Aram-naharaim. This name describes North Mesopotamia, where Balaam's hometown of Pethor was located (Numbers 22:5).
- the mountains of the east: This refers to a mountain range in North Syria.

Numbers 23:13–26

Balak hoped for different results by changing the location. The exact location of the plateau of Zophim on Pisgah Peak is unknown. Yet, Pisgah is part of the ridge that is above the plains of Moab (Deuteronomy 34:1). It is near Bamoth-baal and Mount Peor (Numbers 22:41; 23:28).

Numbers 23:18–24

This message emphasizes God's faithfulness to his people. He would remain with them and keep all the promises he had made.

Nothing would cause him to abandon his word or turn away from Israel.

Numbers 23:19

Because God is faithful and always keeps his word, Balaam had no choice but to bless Israel.

He could not speak against them because God had decided to bless them.

Numbers 23:20–21

The Lord kept his promises to bless his people, bringing them no misfortune or trouble. Balaam could not change God's plans. God punished the Hebrews for disobedience. Yet, he supported Israel's cause ever since he freed them from Egypt.

Numbers 23:23–24

No curse could overpower Israel because God blessed them (Numbers 22:12; compare Genesis 12:2–3; 22:17–18). Israel was safe from the harm that Moab and Midian tried to cause through divination (compare Numbers 24:1). Israel would become famous because God protected them from harm (see Joshua 2:9–11; compare Numbers 14:13–19).

Numbers 23:27–24.14

Unhappy with Balaam's blessing, Balak hoped a new location would change the outcome. Although the exact location of Mount Peor is unknown, it was probably near a worship site for Baal of Peor and the Beth-peor (compare 25:3, 5). See Deuteronomy 3:29; 34:6 for where they buried Moses.

Numbers 24:1–2

Unlike before, Balaam did not use divination this time (23:3, 15). He already knew that signs and omens could not harm Israel (23:23). So he stopped looking for them.

Instead, the Spirit of God came directly upon Balaam. God himself gave Balaam the message to speak.

Numbers 24:3–9

The third message describes God's plan to bless Israel again.

Numbers 24:5–6

God showed his love for his people by giving them many blessings. These blessings were signs of his care and favor toward Israel.

Numbers 24:6–7

The Lord's favor is shown by comparing Israel to groves and gardens that have plenty of water. In a dry land,

water brings life and growth. This picture shows how God was caring for his people.

Israel's growing population also showed God's blessing (24:7; as mentioned in 23:10). This growth would become even clearer in the second census recorded in chapter 26.

Numbers 24:7–9

- God's blessing would allow the Israelites defeat their enemies (see 24:15–24).
- Agag was an Amalekite king whom King Saul defeated (1 Samuel 15:7–9, 32–33). The Amalekites, a desert people, were traditional enemies of the Hebrews (compare Numbers 14:45; Exodus 17:8–16). Agag was probably a traditional title for their king. Since God brought Israel out of Egypt, he fought for them like a warrior and a wild animal (wild ox and lion; Numbers 24:8–9).
- Blessed ... cursed: See Genesis 12:3; 27:29.

Numbers 24:10

Balak clapped his hands to show anger and disapproval (see also Job 27:23; Lamentations 2:15).

Numbers 24:14

come, let me warn you what this people will do to your people in the days to come: Since Balak tried to curse Israel, God would curse him and his people (24:9). The harm Balak wanted to cause Israel will instead happen to Moab.

Numbers 24:15–25

This prophecy gives more specific details than the first three messages. It is based on another vision from God (the Most High, 24:16). It also predicts the appearance of a great leader who will play a major role in these military victories (24:17).

Numbers 24:17

- A star symbolized a king (see Isaiah 14:12; Matthew 2:1–10). A scepter symbolized power and majesty (see Genesis 49:10; Psalm 45:6).

Historically, King David fits this description. The Moabites, whose defeat Numbers 24:17 mentions, were among the many peoples he conquered during David's rule (2 Samuel 8:2). Yet, Moab remained a threat to Israel after David's time (see 2 Kings 3:1–27; Isaiah 15–16; Jeremiah 48).

Many interpreters have extended this image beyond David. Christians identify Jesus of Nazareth with a star and a scepter (compare Matthew 2:2; 2 Peter 1:19; Revelation 2:28; 22:16; compare Hebrews 1:8).

- the sons of Sheth: These people were probably the ancient Sutu, a group known from other records.

However, the name may refer to a different people group. It could refer to:

- Edom, also called Seir, which David later defeated (Numbers 24:18),
- Ir, or Ar, a city of Moab (24:19; compare 21:28), or
- Amalek, one of Israel's earliest and most lasting enemies (24:20).

Numbers 24:21–22

Assyria would destroy the Kenites, a desert people living in the same areas as the Amalekites and Midianites. Moses married a Kenite (Judges 1:16; 4:11; compare Numbers 10:29–32). The Kenites were mostly friendly with Israel after that time (for example, 1 Samuel 15:6; 27:10; 30:27–30).

Numbers 24:23

This verse is similar to 22:12 and summarizes the lesson of the entire event.

Numbers 24:23–24

The message concludes by mentioning the appearance and downfall of invaders from Cyprus. The Hebrew term Kittim probably referred to various Mediterranean groups (compare Genesis 10:4; Jeremiah 2:10; Daniel 11:30).

Numbers 24:24

Eber has the same spelling as the ancestor of the Hebrews (compare Genesis 10:21–25; 11:10–16). It may refer to a people on the other side of the Euphrates River. This region fits the parallel reference to Assyria (see Joshua 24:3; Isaiah 7:20).

Numbers 24:25

Balaam did not yet go back to Pethor (31:8).

Numbers 25:1

- in Shittim: From here, Joshua later sent spies across the Jordan River, and the Hebrews began their conquest (Joshua 2:1; 3:1).
- daughters of Moab: The Moabites and the Midianites both shared responsibility for what happened with Balaam (Numbers 22:2–4, 7; 31:8, 15–16).

Numbers 25:1–18

Israel was camped across the Jordan River from Jericho. They were almost ready to enter the land and begin the conquest. However, at this important moment, they fell into serious sin.

Balaam advised Israel's enemies to lead the people into sexual immorality and idolatry at Baal-peor (31:16).

He could not harm Israel with a curse, so he chose another way. He led them into sin through lust and the worship of false gods.

The early church faced similar temptations. Believers were warned about idolatry and sexual immorality (1 Corinthians 10:6, 11).

Numbers 25:2

The Israelites participated in worship feasts associated with the gods of Moab (see Psalm 106:28).

Numbers 25:3

- Baal of Peor might refer to Chemosh by another name (21:29). More likely, it refers to Baal, which means "lord." Baal was a Canaanite god. The Moabites honored several gods, and Baal was probably one of them.

Many place names include the name Baal, such as Baal-gad, Baal-hermon, Baal-meon, and Baal-peor. These names likely marked local shrines where people worshiped Baal in different forms.
Peor was a mountain from which Balaam could see the camp of Israel in the plains of Moab. Nearby was a shrine called Beth-peor (23:28; 25:3, 5, 18; 31:16; Deuteronomy 3:29; 4:3, 46; 34:6; Joshua 13:20; 22:17).

- Israel's worship of false gods made the Lord very angry. As a result, a plague broke out among the people (Numbers 25:8–9; 26:1; compare 11:1, 10; 12:9).

Numbers 25:4

- As at Sinai, the Lord required quick justice (Exodus 32:27–28).
- execute them in broad daylight: They may have killed the guilty people and hung them on a pole. Then they would leave them in the sun so everyone could see and learn from their mistakes (see 2 Samuel 21:6, 9; compare 2 Samuel 12:12).

Numbers 25:6

- In this event, another Israelite man made himself unclean by being with a foreign woman. Both Moabite and Midianite women were involved in this scandal (25:1–3, 16–18; 31:1–2).

His sin was especially bold. He acted without shame, even though people around him were mourning because of God's judgment.

- Some interpreters suggest that his tent may have been more than his personal dwelling. They think it may have been an unauthorized shrine connected with the worship of Yahweh. If so, this would have made his sin even more serious.

Numbers 25:7–9

Phinehas, acting as a representative of the priestly family, killed Zimri and Cozbi with one thrust of a spear (25:7–8). The text likely suggests that they were engaged in sexual relations at that moment.

Phinehas acted with zeal, which means strong passion to defend God's honor. His action brought the plague to an end (25:1–3).

Numbers 25:10–13

Israel's identity as the Lord's people was in great danger because they were unfaithful at this time. Their sin threatened their special relationship with God.

Phinehas showed strong zeal (deep commitment and passion) for God's holiness and justice. He acted in a way that matched God's own concern for what is right. Because of this, God gave Phinehas and his descendants a special blessing.

God made a covenant of peace (a lasting promise of peace and favor) with Phinehas. The men in his family who were qualified could serve as priests forever (compare Malachi 2:5).

This covenant was unconditional (it did not depend on future actions). It was similar to the covenant God made with David (see Jeremiah 33:19–22).

Numbers 25:13

The deaths of Zimri and Cozbi helped remove sin from the community of Israel. Their judgment stopped the spread of sin among the people.

Phinehas's action had atoning value. This means it helped turn away God's judgment and restore the people's relationship with him. His act brought cleansing and peace to Israel (see study note on Leviticus 1:4).

Numbers 25:16–18

Attack the Midianites and strike them dead: This war is recorded in chapter 31.

Numbers 26:1–4

As in the first census, Moses and Eleazar directed the counting of the people. Eleazar had taken Aaron's place as high priest.

They gave instructions to the tribal leaders about how to record the numbers of the men.

Numbers 26:1–65

After nearly 40 years, Israel registered their men of military age again. This was while camping on the plains of Moab across from Jericho (compare chapters 1–4). The overall population changed only slightly, with 603,550 in the first registration and 601,730 in the second. This nearly complete replacement of the population showed that the Lord remained faithful to Israel despite their repeated acts of rebellion (26:63–65).

Numbers 26:8–11

the line of Korah did not die out: See study note on 16:31–33 for more information.

Numbers 26:33

The daughters of Zelophehad began an important change in Israel's law (see 27:1–11; 36:1–12).

Numbers 26:51

Despite wars, plagues, and punishments, God remained faithful to Israel. The number of male warriors decreased by 1,820 compared to the first count. This was a difference of 0.3 percent (compare 2:32).

Numbers 26:52–56

- The second registration, like the first, was for military purposes. It also helped distribute land to Israel's tribes based on their populations (see Joshua 15–19).
- the land must be divided by lot: People used lots to seek guidance from God and prevent favoritism in important matters (for example, Numbers 27:21; 1 Samuel 10:20; 14:41–42; Proverbs 18:18; Acts 1:26).

Numbers 26:57–61

The family of Kohath received special attention as the clan of Aaron, Moses, and Miriam.

Numbers 26:62

- Moses counted the Levites separately (compare 1:47–49; 3:14–39).
- a month old or more: Compare 3:15.
- The Levites did not receive a land allotment when the Israelites divided the land. Instead, they received 48 towns for their use, but no large territory as described in 26:52–56. (35:1–8; compare 18:23–24).

Numbers 26:63–65

The numbers in this second registration describe a completely new generation of Hebrews. Everyone who had left Egypt had died in the wilderness except Caleb and Joshua.

Joshua became the leader of Israel after Moses (27:12–23; see "Joshua" Profile). Caleb also later played an important role in Israel's history (see "Caleb" Profile).

Numbers 26 shows an important change. The earlier generation had lived under God's judgment because of their unbelief (chapter 14). Now a new generation stood ready for the future, just as Balaam's four prophecies had promised (chapters 23–24).

Numbers 27:1–11

Zelophehad did not have any sons, which allowed for changes to the inheritance laws. They would later refine these laws more (compare 36:1–13).

Numbers 27:2

the entrance of the Tent of Meeting: This was the most important public place, where leaders made important decisions. Joshua 17:4 specifically mentions Eleazar, Joshua, and the Hebrew leaders. But it does not mention Moses. These women asked for an exception to the existing law and presented their case to the highest tribal authorities.

Numbers 27:3–4

Zelophehad had not joined Korah's rebellion (16:1–50).If he had taken part in that rebellion, he may have lost his property rights because of his sin (see 15:30; compare 1 Kings 21:7–16).

Israelite society was patriarchal and patrilineal. This means that family ancestry and property were passed down through the male line. Normally, sons inherited their father's land.

Zelophehad had no sons. His daughters wanted their father's land to remain in their family. They asked for property rights equal to those given to sons. Their request was reasonable and based on a desire to preserve their family's inheritance.

Numbers 27:5–11

Moses brought their case before the Lord. The Lord accepted the women's request.

God then established their case as a general rule. This new rule helped preserve property within families when there were no sons to inherit it.

Numbers 27:12

this mountan of the Abarim range: This was probably Mount Nebo (Deuteronomy 32:49). From this mountain, Moses looked over the promised land shortly before he died (Deuteronomy 34:1).

Numbers 27:12–23

Israel needed a leader when they entered the land of Canaan. Joshua was chosen to follow Moses.

Numbers 27:15–17

Israel was about to begin a long battle for Canaan. Moses did not want them to struggle without a leader or become lost like sheep without a shepherd (compare 1 Kings 22:17; Ezekiel 34:5; Matthew 9:36).

Numbers 27:18–19

- Joshua was well prepared to become Israel's leader. He had already led Israel in battle (compare Exodus 17:8–16). He had also served as Moses's assistant for many years (Numbers 11:28; compare Exodus 33:11).

Joshua was one of the two faithful spies who knew the people of Israel well (Numbers 13–14). The Spirit of God was with Joshua (compare 11:25–29). His close relationship with God gave him wisdom for the work ahead (for example, Deuteronomy 34:9).

- lay your hands on him: This act symbolized transferring authority from an elder leader to his assistant (compare Numbers 8:10–14). Moses did this publicly so that no one would question Joshua's leadership.

Numbers 27:20–21

Joshua received only part of the authority Moses had. Moses had spoken with God face to face (12:6–8; Deuteronomy 34:10–12). Joshua did not have that same direct access to God's revelation.

Instead, Joshua had to seek guidance through Eleazar the priest on important matters (Numbers 27:21; compare Exodus 28:30; Leviticus 8:8). Eleazar used the priestly means of seeking God's will.

From this time on, Israel separated military leadership from spiritual leadership. Joshua led the army, while the priest guided the people in spiritual matters.

Numbers 28:1–2

The Lord accepted special gifts as a pleasing aroma (compare 15:3). This means God accepted and enjoyed these gifts (see also Genesis 8:21; Leviticus 1:9; Ephesians 5:2; Philippians 4:18). The priests made offerings at set times following specific instructions (see Numbers 28:3–29:39).

Numbers 28:1–29.40

- These two chapters describe Israel's ceremonial calendar. It listed daily, weekly, and monthly offerings, along with annual religious events. God instructed Israel to worship him "in a proper and orderly manner" (1 Corinthians 14:40).

The annual sacrifices required many animals, grain, oil, and wine. On these special days, Israel stopped their usual work. This was a sacrifice that emphasized the importance of these holy days.
The annual cycle included eight different occasions for worship, each reflecting Israel's relationship with the Lord. Each event involved different combinations of burnt, grain, liquid, or sin offerings.

- For details on grain and liquid offerings, see Numbers 15:1–16. For explanations of different offerings, see Leviticus 1:1–7:38. For a description of Israel's festivals, see Leviticus 23:1–44. For the New Testament view on the Old Testament sacrificial system, see John 1:29; Romans 12:1; Hebrews 9:9–15; 10:1–2; 1 Peter 2:5.

Numbers 28:2

the food: See study notes on Exodus 29:18 and Deuteronomy 8:2.

Numbers 28:3–8

- The daily offering was the foundation of the sacrificial system. This practice began at Mount Sinai (see Exodus 29:38–46).
- fermented drink: Compare Numbers 6:3; Leviticus 10:9; Deuteronomy 14:26.

Numbers 28:9–10

Special days required extra offerings. On the Sabbath, people made a sacrifice in addition to the regular burnt offering and its liquid offering. Other passages emphasize the importance of the Sabbath (for example, Exodus 20:8–11; Leviticus 23:3; Deuteronomy 5:12–15).

Numbers 28:11–15

The first day of each month was the new moon. On that day, the people sacrificed bulls, rams, and lambs as burnt offerings. They also sacrificed a male goat as a sin offering (an offering for forgiveness of sin).

Numbers 28:16–25

The Passover, followed by the Feast of Unleavened Bread, was the first of five major annual feasts. It took place in early spring (March or April). The Passover did not require public sacrifices. It was a family event celebrated at home (see also 9:1–4; Exodus 12:1–13:10; Leviticus 23:5–8; Deuteronomy 16:1–8).

This festival is important in the background of the Last Supper (see Matthew 26:17–19, 26–27; Mark 14:12; John 11:55; 12:1; 13:1; 18:28, 39; 19:14, 31; compare 1 Corinthians 5:7).

Numbers 28:26–31

The Feast of Weeks was later called the Feast of Pentecost (see Acts 2:1; also Leviticus 23:15–22). It marked the end of the barley harvest and the start of the wheat harvest in early summer (May or June). The Greek name Pentecost means "fiftieth." It refers to the fiftieth day after Passover (see Acts 20:16; 1 Corinthians 16:8).

Numbers 29:1–6

a day for you to sound the trumpets: See also Leviticus 23:23–25.

Numbers 29:7

On the tenth day of this seventh month: Today this day is known as Yom Kippur. The name comes from the Hebrew yom hakkippurim, which means "day of atonement" (a day for seeking forgiveness for sin, Leviticus 23:27).

Numbers 29:7–11

The Day of Atonement was a serious and holy day. It was a day of fasting, when the people did not eat food as a sign of repentance and prayer (see also Leviticus 16; 23:26–32; Romans 3:23–25; Hebrews 9:7–12, 23–28).

Numbers 29:12–38

The Feast of Tabernacles began on the fifteenth day of the seventh month. It was an eight-day harvest celebration that required many offerings (Numbers 29:12, 35; Exodus 34:22). This festival was a joyful time for giving thanks (see Nehemiah 8:13–18). The tabernacles (or shelters) reminded the Israelites of living in tents during their time in the wilderness (see also Leviticus 23:33–43; 1 Kings 8:1–2).

Numbers 29:39

The public offerings were not the only sacrifices. People also brought their own voluntary gifts (see Leviticus 23:38).

Numbers 30:1–2

Vows included promises to give offerings, like Hannah's vow in 1 Samuel 1. It included pledges to abstain from certain things, like the Nazirite vow in Numbers 6. Jesus mentioned the teachings about vows in the Sermon on the Mount in Matthew 5:33.

Numbers 30:1–16

Vows were an important way to show devotion or piety. But people sometimes made them quickly and forgot them. People often made voluntary pledges during special religious events or in times of war. The mention of vows and voluntary offerings might have led to further discussion here (29:39; compare 15:3; see also 6:1–21; Leviticus 5:4–5; 27:1–34; Deuteronomy 23:21–23).

These instructions applied to Hannah and Elkanah (1 Samuel 1:1–28). Such practices, including fasting, continued into the New Testament period (for example, Matthew 6:16; 15:3–9; Acts 18:18; 21:23). Vows made by females needed approval from the responsible male who would share financial responsibility for the vow. This applied to young and unmarried or adult and married women. No one, male or female, young or old, should make a vow to God and then ignore it.

Numbers 30:3–5

A young woman was under her father's authority. He was responsible for her actions and financial obligations.

Numbers 30:6–8

When a young Hebrew woman married, her husband gained authority over her. He could cancel any vow or pledge she made while under her father's authority. This was only true if he canceled it as soon as he heard about it.

Numbers 30:9

A widow or divorced woman usually returned to her father's family (Leviticus 22:13). Yet, a mature single woman who made a vow or pledge had to fulfill her religious duties.

Numbers 30:10–15

A married woman needed her husband's approval to make vows and pledges. Her husband could cancel her religious promise. But he had to decide on the day he heard about it. God did not blame the married woman for breaking the promise if her husband canceled it correctly (compare 30:5, 8, 12).

The self-denial mentioned in 30:13 probably refers to fasting. If he did not object, the husband's silence meant he agreed. He could not delay his objection, or he would be guilty of a broken vow (compare Leviticus 5:4–13).

Numbers 31:1–2

The Lord instructed Moses to lead Israel in a war against the Midianites. The Midianites had joined the Moabites in influencing the Hebrews to worship idols (chapter 25). The Midianites were a tribal people living in the dry regions south and east of Palestine and east of the Jordan River. They were among the "people of the east" (Judges 6:3, 33; 7:12). They lived in camps or settlements and were famous for their desert transportation skills (compare Genesis 37:28, 36; Isaiah 60:6).

They descended from Abraham and had been friendly to Moses (Genesis 25:1–2; Exodus 2:15–3:1; compare Numbers 10:29). Yet, the elders of Midian joined Balak in hiring Balaam to curse Israel (22:4, 7). Israel's presence threatened the peoples of Transjordan (the area east of the Jordan River).

Numbers 31:3–5

Each tribe sent 1,000 men to the battle. This allowed everyone to gain combat experience and share the victory.

Numbers 31:6

- Phinehas, son of Eleazar the high priest, led this force of 12,000 men into battle. His leadership showed that this battle was considered a "holy war" (a war carried out in obedience to God). It was an act of judgment for the spiritual harm that Midian had caused Israel (see 25:6–18; 31:15–16). His zeal in this situation matched his actions in the case of Zimri and Cozbi (Numbers 25:11, 13; 25:7–8).
- Many scholars believe the holy objects of the holy place included the ark of the covenant, which the Hebrews sometimes carried into battle (for example, Numbers 10:35–36; Joshua 6:6; 1 Samuel 4:3–11; see also Numbers 14:44). Other scholars suggest they were various holy objects used in Tent of Meeting ceremonies (3:31; 4:15; 18:3; see also 1 Kings 8:4; 1 Chronicles 9:29; 2 Chronicles 5:5). The Israelites likely took some or all of these holy objects as signs that God was with them in this battle.

Numbers 31:7

The Israelites killed all of the Midianite men in the particular groups they attacked from their camp in the plains of Moab (31:12). They did not destroy all the Midianites who were part of the larger Midianite alliance (compare Judges 6–8). The number of animals and virgins mentioned in Numbers 31:32–35 shows that the 12,000 Hebrews fought a large enemy army.

Numbers 31:8

Balaam son of Beor was put to death because his advice caused the people of Israel to turn against the Lord at Mount Peor (Numbers 31:16). He was judged for his evil actions (compare 2 Peter 2:15; Jude 1:11).

Numbers 31:9–13

After the battle, the Hebrews began the practice that they sometimes followed throughout the period of conquest and beyond (for example, Joshua 6; 8; 10–11). They destroyed their enemies (sometimes the total population), burned towns, and set aside spoils for their own use or as dedicated to the Lord.

Numbers 31:10

cities ... encampments: These places included both large towns and smaller camps without walls.

Numbers 31:13

outside the camp: The returning troops probably observed ceremonies to make themselves ceremonially clean. This was to avoid making the Tent of Meeting and the people unclean through contact with dead bodies (31:19–24).

Numbers 31:14–16

Moses was angry: God had commanded the Israelites to destroy everything. But the Midianite women who had followed Balaam's advice were allowed to live. These women had played a major role in leading Israel into sin at Baal Peor.

Numbers 31:17–18

Only young, virgin women were to be spared. They were allowed to live because they had not taken part in the sin at Baal Peor.

Numbers 31:19–24

Israelite soldiers who touched dead bodies became ceremonially unclean (ritually impure). They had to go through the required purification rituals.

These rituals were routine, but they were important. They also had to purify their equipment (see 5:1–4; 19:1–22).

Numbers 31:25–31

They divided the plunder into two equal parts. Half went to those who fought against the Midianites and half to the Israelites who stayed behind (compare 1 Samuel 30:21–25). In this way, everyone participated in the conflict. Yet, the smaller group of soldiers each received a larger portion than the much larger group who stayed behind.

Numbers 31:32–35

The total number of animals and young girls who were not killed was quite large, which shows that Israel fought against many Midianites.

Numbers 31:36–47

The plunder was distributed according to the principles established in 31:25–30.

Numbers 31:48–49

It is unusual for an army to lose no soldiers in battle, but it is not impossible. Ancient writers also described battles in which few or no Roman soldiers were killed.

If the Israelites were well prepared and attacked by surprise, and if they had many more soldiers than their enemies, they could have won the battle without losing any men. This would be even more likely because of God's blessing.

Numbers 31:50–54

The commanders happily offered gold objects to show gratitude for a great victory with no loss of life (see Exodus 30:12). Ancient art and literature show that the Midianites and other desert peoples, both men and women, wore gold jewelry. They used it as decoration, and as a form of wealth they could take with them (for example, Judges 8:24–26).

Moses and Eleazar brought this large collection to the Tent of Meeting as a memorial of this special event (compare Numbers 16:39–40; Zechariah 6:14).

Numbers 32:1

- very large herds and flocks: The Israelites had flocks and herds when they left Egypt (see Exodus 12:38). They gained more animals as plunder in the war with Midian (see Numbers 31:32–33). They might have also gained it in their victories over Sihon and Og (see 21:21–35).
- Gilead can refer to either the entire northern region of the plateau east of the Jordan River (for example, 32:29). It can also refer only to the land between the Jabbok River and the Arnon River.

Numbers 32:1–5

After Israel took control of the central area east of the Jordan River, during the battles described in chapter 21, they began preparing to enter Canaan.

At that time, the Israelites needed to remain united. But two tribes asked for permission to settle on the east side of the Jordan River instead of crossing into Canaan.

Numbers 32:3

- Reuben, Gad, and half of Manasseh settled in the land Israel had recently captured from Sihon the Amorite and Og of Bashan (see 21:21–35).
- Ataroth, Dibon, Jazer, Nimrah, Heshbon, and Elealeh have been connected with known archaeological sites. These places have been identified with ruins that researchers have studied.
- The location of Sebam is unknown.
- The exact location of the town called Nebo is not known. However, it was likely near a mountain or ridge with the same name. This mountain stood along the steep slope (escarpment) that rises above the northern end of the Dead Sea.
- The place called Beon is almost certainly the same as "Baal-meon" in 32:38. It likely matches the ruins at Ma'in.

Numbers 32:6–15

Moses assumed that Reuben and Gad wanted to stay east of the Jordan River to avoid the dangers that awaited the other tribes in Canaan (compare chapters 13–14).

Numbers 32:12

Caleb is identified as a Kenizzite, a descendant of Esau (see Genesis 36:10–11). This suggests that Caleb was not born as an Israelite. He may have been a convert (someone who joined Israel's faith). Even so, he became fully part of Israel's life and worship.

Later, Caleb represented the tribe of Judah when Moses sent out the twelve spies to explore the promised land (Numbers 13:6).

Numbers 32:16–19

The Reubenites and Gadites assured Moses that they would not discourage their fellow Israelites and would support the war to its very end. There were still dangers east of the Jordan River, so they wanted to keep their livestock and families safe.

Numbers 32:20–24

Moses agreed to the terms offered by Reuben and Gad. If they helped their relatives fight the Canaanites, they would fulfill their part of the agreement. Then they could return to their settlements east of the Jordan River (32:22). If they did not keep their promise, it would be a serious sin against God (32:23).

Numbers 32:25–27

Reuben and Gad kept their promise (Joshua 4:12–13; 22:1–9).

Numbers 32:28–30

Israel's leaders were Eleazar, Joshua, and the heads of clans. They would help enforce the commands of Moses since he would soon die (compare Joshua 22:1–2).

Numbers 32:31–32

Gad and Reuben reaffirmed their pledge before all of Israel's leaders.

Numbers 32:33–42

- The tribes of Gad and Reuben, along with half the tribe of Manasseh, settled east of the Jordan River (for example, Deuteronomy 3:12–13; 4:43; 29:7–8). These tribes lived in lands and towns captured from King Sihon the Amorite and King Og of Bashan (Numbers 32:33; see 21:21–35).
- Half the tribe of Manasseh suddenly appears in the discussion about distributing the land. Part of Manasseh's tribe settled east of the Jordan River, while another part settled in Canaan, west of the Jordan (compare Joshua 17:1–12; 22:7).

Numbers 32:34–36

The exact locations of Atroth-shophan, Jogbehah, and Beth-haran are unknown. Aroer was on the northern edge of the Arnon canyon.

Numbers 32:37–38

Some towns may have received new names to remove connections with pagan gods. For example, Baal was the name of a well-known Canaanite god. Nebo was the name of a Babylonian god (see Isaiah 46:1). However, this passage does not give the new names of those towns.

Numbers 32:39–42

- Three clans of Manasseh conquered part of Gilead and Bashan (compare Deuteronomy 3:13–15; Joshua 13:29–31). The exact location of Nobah is still unknown (compare Judges 8:11).
- Havvoth-jair: Compare Deuteronomy 3:14; Joshua 13:30; Judges 10:4; 1 Kings 4:13; 1 Chronicles 2:21–23).

Numbers 33:1–2

The list of travel places shows careful record-keeping. It includes many specific details. This is the only place in Numbers that says Moses wrote down part of Israel's history (compare Exodus 24:4).

Numbers 33:1–56

- This review of the entire wilderness period includes the longest connected list of place names in the Old Testament. It begins with Israel's departure from Egypt (33:3; compare Exodus 12:37). It ends with their arrival in the plains of Moab, across from Jericho (Numbers 33:49; compare 22:1).

The list names 42 stopping places along the way. These places represent more than a physical journey from one land to another. They also remind readers of Israel's forty years of spiritual growth and testing.
Israel traveled from Rameses in Egypt (33:3) to Abel-shittim on the plains of Moab (33:49). During these years, the people became ready to enter the land of Canaan and receive the promises God had made to Abraham.

- This list does not give enough information to trace an exact route on a map. Many of the places cannot be identified with certainty. Some of these names do not appear anywhere else in the Hebrew Bible.

In addition, there are not enough details to locate these places precisely. The list is also selective. It does not include every place that earlier parts of the journey mention.

Numbers 33:3

marched out defiantly: See Exodus 14:8.

Numbers 33:4

executed judgment against their gods: See Exodus 6:6; 12:12. This historical review emphasizes the special events that forced Pharaoh to allow the Israelites to leave Egypt.

Numbers 33:5–15

For the list of Israel's travel places between Rameses and the wilderness of Sinai, see Exodus 13:17–19:1.

Numbers 33:6

Etham: See Exodus 13:20.

Numbers 33:9

The exact location of Elim is not known. However, it may have been the oasis (a place with water, springs, and palm trees) at Wadi Gharandel.

Numbers 33:14

The entry for Rephidim (see study note on 20:13) includes a reminder that Israel rebelled there (Exodus 7:1–7).

Numbers 33:15

Tradition associates the wilderness of Sinai with a mountainous region in the southern Sinai Peninsula near Jebel Musa (Arabic for "mountain of Moses"), though scholars have suggested other locations.

Numbers 33:16–17

Kibroth-hattaavah ... Hazeroth: See 11:34–12:16.

Numbers 33:16–36

The journey between Sinai and Kadesh. Our ability to locate the named sites depends on the identification of Mount Sinai.

Numbers 33:18–30

Most of the names of the places in this section do not appear elsewhere in the Old Testament.

Numbers 33:30–31

Moseroth was also known as Moserah (Deuteronomy 10:6). This is where Aaron died and was buried (compare Numbers 20:22–29; 33:37–39).

Numbers 33:35

Ezion-geber was located near the northern end of the Gulf of Aqaba (see Deuteronomy 2:8).

Numbers 33:36

Israel was living in Kadesh when the spies returned and gave the report of their journey through Canaan (13:26; 27:14; "Kadesh-barnea," 32:8).

Numbers 33:37–49

Israel traveled from Kadesh to the plains of Moab.

Numbers 33:38–39

These details about Aaron's death and his age show that he was about three years older than Moses (compare Numbers 20:22–29; Deuteronomy 31:1–2; 34:7).

Numbers 33:42–49

Many possible locations for these places are east of the Jordan River. They lie between the southern Arabah and the plains of Moab, across from Jericho.

Numbers 33:47

Almon-diblathaim is probably the same place as Beth-diblathaim (Jeremiah 48:22). This place is also mentioned in the Mesha Inscription, an ancient Moabite stone monument (see study note on Numbers 21:26).

Numbers 33:50–56

After the Israelites arrived at the plains of Moab, across from Jericho (22:1), they camped there. They remained in that place for the rest of the events recorded in Numbers (see 36:13; Deuteronomy 34:8).

While they camped there, God gave Israel specific instructions on how to deal with the people of Canaan. The Lord commanded them to destroy the people groups living in Canaan and remove all traces of their religious practices (compare Exodus 23:23–33; 34:11–17; Deuteronomy 7:1–6; 12:2–4; Joshua 23:4–8).

Moses said they must destroy carved and metal idols (compare Leviticus 26:1). They were also to tear down pagan places of worship (see Deuteronomy 12:2–3).

Numbers 33:54

divide the land by lot: See 26:53–56. Chapter 34 describes the boundaries of the land of Canaan, which they would soon conquer and divide.

Numbers 33:55–56

Israel did not follow God's instructions. So, they suffered the consequences predicted here (33:51–53; see Judges 1:1–2:5; 2:11–3:6). Israel's enemies in the period of the judges were like "barbs ... and thorns" (Numbers

33:55). Their enemies caused them military and spiritual trouble (compare 2 Corinthians 12:7).

Numbers 34:1–29

Chapter 34 describes the borders of Canaan. This is where God commanded Israel to settle, following the guidelines in 26:52–56. Since Abraham's call, the promised land of Canaan has been central to the Old Testament story (Genesis 12:1–7). A generation of Hebrews died in the wilderness for not believing what the faithful spies reported (Numbers 13). Yet, God reaffirmed his promise of land (33:53).

Here, God reviews the plan and outlines the promised land's intended boundaries (compare Joshua 13–19; Ezekiel 47–48). Old Testament Israel did not fully capture this territory. It almost did during the time of the kings David and Solomon (see 2 Samuel 24:1–9). But these borders generally describe the region of Canaan as defined by Egyptian texts from 1500–1200 BC. This was when the Hebrews invaded. The region actually occupied by Israel changed from time to time.

Numbers 34:3–5

Portions of the southern boundary of Canaan were familiar to Israel from earlier experiences in the Wilderness of Zin, located on the northwestern border of Edom (see chapters 13–14). This southern border curved from the southern end of the Dead Sea to the Mediterranean Sea, running east to west.

Numbers 34:4

From the southern end of the Dead Sea, the boundary ran through the Ascent of Akrabbim toward Zin (compare 13:21). The southernmost point was Kadesh-barnea (see 13:26). Hazar-addar and Azmon are unknown.

Numbers 34:5

The Brook of Egypt is not the Nile River. It refers to a wadi (a dry riverbed that fills with water during the rainy season). This wadi marked the border between Canaan and Egypt and flowed toward the Mediterranean Sea (see 1 Kings 8:65). I

In Old Testament times, Israel had little control over this southern coastal area.

Numbers 34:6–9

- The natural western boundary of Canaan was the Mediterranean coast ("the Great Sea," 34:6). The northern boundary started at the Mediterranean and went east to Mount Hor. This was somewhere in the Lebanon mountain range (not the place of Aaron's death, 20:22–29).
- Lebo-hamath: Compare 13:21; 1 Kings 8:65; Amos 6:14.

Numbers 34:11

Sea of Chinnereth (or Galilee): Its eastern side (literally shoulder) is the ridge that rises steeply from the eastern shore.

Numbers 34:12

The natural eastern border of Canaan followed the Jordan River down to the Salt Sea (or Dead Sea). The Jordan River and the Salt Sea were part of the Great Rift Valley. They were strong barriers, but people could cross them.

This boundary did not include the lands east of the Jordan River. Reuben, Gad, and half of the tribe of Manasseh lived there. These settlements were not part of Canaan. There were outside the first borders of the promised land.

Numbers 34:13–15

Apportion this land by lot: Compare with 26:55–56. Two and a half tribes (Reuben, Gad, and half the tribe of Manasseh) settled in Transjordan (the region east of the Jordan River; compare with 32:33). So, Canaan was to be divided among the nine and a half remaining tribes.

Numbers 34:16–29

Eleazar (the high priest) and Joshua (the political leader) were to divide the land among the remaining tribes. The 10 tribal leaders who would help them are listed in 34:19–28.

Numbers 34:19–28

Caleb son of Jephunneh is the only tribal leader mentioned elsewhere in Numbers (13:6, 30; 14:6–38). Most of the older generation had died during the wilderness period (Numbers 26:63–65). But the two faithful spies were still leading their people.

Numbers 35:1–34

The tribe of Levi did not receive its own land. So chapter 35 explains how they received 48 towns spread out among the lands of the other tribes (see Joshua 21; see also Leviticus 25:32–34; 1 Chronicles 13:2; 2 Chronicles 11:14).

During the wilderness journey, the Levites lived in the center of the Israelite camp (compare Numbers

2:17). In the promised land, they were to live among the other tribes. Their presence was meant to influence the people for good (see Deuteronomy 33:9–10; 2 Chronicles 17:7–9; 19:8–11; 35:3).

These towns and their pasturelands were not a separate homeland (compare Numbers 18:23; 26:62). They were only a small portion of the land of Canaan, divided among the other tribes.

Numbers 35:4–5

Some have tried to explain the supposed contradiction between the 1,000 cubits (457 meters or 1,500 feet) and the 2,000 cubits (914 meters or 3,000 feet). One explanation is that the Hebrews thought of a town as a fixed center point. If so, the land around each town would form a square that measured 914 meters (3,000 feet) on each side.

Another explanation is that there is a difference between the smaller pastureland mentioned in Numbers 35:4 and the larger pastureland mentioned in 35:5.

Based on this text, some Jewish teachers later limited how far a person could walk on the Sabbath. They said a person could walk no more than 2,000 cubits (914 meters or 3,000 feet) from home.

Numbers 35:6–34

Six of the Levites' towns had a special purpose. They served as cities of refuge. A city of refuge was a place where a person could run for safety after accidentally killing someone.

These cities show the humanitarian (care for human life) side of Hebrew law (see also Deuteronomy 4:41–43; 19:1–13; Joshua 20).

These six towns offered protection when someone killed accidentally or unintentionally (compare Exodus 21:12–14).

The 48 towns given to the Levites were spread throughout Israel. In the same way, the six cities of refuge were placed in different parts of the land. This made them easy to reach for anyone who needed safety (see Joshua 20:7–8).

Before these cities were established, a person could sometimes seek safety by holding on to the altar. The altar was a place connected with worship (for example, 1 Kings 1:50–53; 2:28–34; compare Exodus 21:14).

Other ancient peoples also had places of refuge. Often these places were connected to an altar (see Exodus 21:12–14; 1 Kings 2:28–34). However, only ancient Israel created entire towns as places of safety. This practice shows Israel's special concern for justice and the protection of human life.

Numbers 35:12

a refuge from the avenger: Justice was carried out through vengeance. A designated avenger, usually a close relative of the person who died, took this role.

Numbers 35:15

the Israelites and for the foreigner or stranger among them … anyone: The same law applied equally to everyone. Israel had one standard of justice for everyone. This was unlike many societies that had different laws for citizens and noncitizens (see also Leviticus 19:15; Deuteronomy 1:16–17; 1 Timothy 5:21; James 2:2–4).

Numbers 35:15–24

- The Old Testament clearly distinguishes between intentional murder and accidental killing (35:11, 22–23; Exodus 21:12–14; compare Numbers 15:22–31). Murder required a penalty of execution, but an accidental death did not. Murder required a penalty of execution, but an accidental death did not.
- If a person used a weapon, this showed malicious intent (a plan to harm someone).

Numbers 35:19

The avenger was the victim's closest relative. He was responsible for putting the murderer to death, carrying out the vengeance that justice required (Genesis 9:6).

Numbers 35:22–23

Sometimes a person died, but the death was not caused by an intentional act of violence. In these cases, the person who caused the death did not plan or mean to kill anyone.

The cities of refuge were created as places of safety for people who were responsible for these accidental deaths. These cities protected them until the community could examine the case and decide what was just.

Numbers 35:24–25

- If the person who caused the death was found not guilty of murder at a public trial before the community (compare Deuteronomy 19:11–12), that person had to remain in the city of refuge.

The avenger was not allowed to take revenge. The community had decided that the person was not guilty of murder.

- until the death of the high priest: The death of the high priest likely served as a kind of expiation (a way of removing guilt or cleansing from sin) for the blood that had been shed. Even if the person did not commit murder, the spilling of human blood was believed to pollute the land (see Numbers 35:33; compare Genesis 4:10–11).

Numbers 35:26–29

The killer (manslayer) had to stay in a special city (called a "city of refuge") as a consequence for the death he had caused. He had to stay in a city of refuge until he or the high priest died. After the high priest's death, the manslayer could return home, and the avenger of blood could not take revenge.

Numbers 35:30

All murderers were condemned to death, but their conviction required a high standard of evidence. This included testimony from two or more witnesses (compare Deuteronomy 17:6; 19:15).

Numbers 35:31–32

The law did not allow the payment of a ransom (money paid as compensation) to free a convicted murderer from execution. The death penalty was required for murder (compare 2 Samuel 21:2–9). Similarly, a person who caused an accidental death could not pay money to avoid staying in a city of refuge. That person had to remain there until the proper time.

Numbers 35:33

for bloodshed pollutes the land: If the person who caused a death, whether murder or accidental killing, was not treated as the law commanded, God viewed the land as polluted.

Human bloodshed required death as a response (Genesis 4:10–11; 9:6). This rule is different from cases such as Exodus 21:29–30 (see also Leviticus 18:28; Ezekiel 36:17–18; Hosea 4:2–3).

This strong warning about murder shows the great value of human life (Exodus 20:13).

Numbers 35:34

The Lord lived among the people of Israel while the Tent of Meeting (the tabernacle) was in the center of the Hebrew camp (see chapters 1–4). This meant that they must not defile their land. They could not ignore God's commands. They also could not fail to carry out justice as the law required (compare 5:1–4).

Numbers 36:1–4

Women who inherited land might marry men from another tribe. Their land would then be lost by their ancestral tribe and transferred to their husband's tribe.

The "Year of Jubilee" usually allowed land to return to its original owner (Leviticus 25:8–55). But it only applied to land sold, not land gained through marriage.

Numbers 36:1–13

The five daughters of Zelophehad requested and received fair property rights (27:1–11). This passage discusses the effects of that decision.

Numbers 36:5

The Lord quickly provided the justice that the men of the tribe of Joseph asked for in their request.

Here, the tribe of Joseph refers to the tribe of Manasseh, the son of Joseph.

Numbers 36:6–9

These rules solved the problem. They ensured that each tribe would keep its land.

In this way, the land given to each tribe would remain stable and continue within that tribe for future generations.

Numbers 36:10–12

Zelophehad's five daughters married their cousins on their father's side, as instructed. This kept their father's land within his clan.

In ancient Hebrew society, marrying a first cousin was acceptable (compare Leviticus 18, 20; see also 1 Chronicles 23:22). Other Near Eastern cultures also accepted this practice.

Numbers 36:13

- commands and ordinances: These might refer to the legal instructions in the whole book (compare Leviticus 27:34). They might also refer only to the laws given on the plains of Moab (Numbers 26–36).
- After this, only one step remained before the Israelites entered Canaan. Moses needed to remind them of their history and their covenant responsibilities. These are the main themes of the book of Deuteronomy.